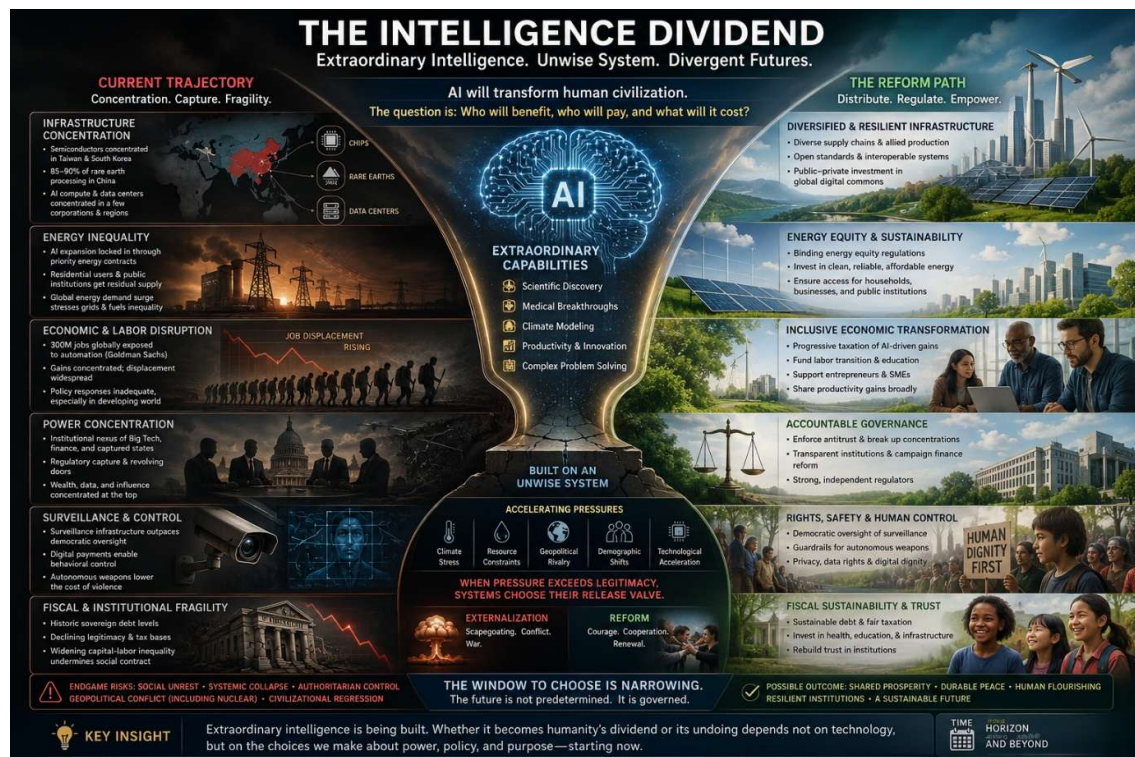


# The Intelligence Dividend: How Humanity May Solve Its Hardest Technical Problems and Lose Everything Else



*A Special Investigation Report on Documented Analysis of Infrastructure Concentration, Institutional Fragility, and the Political Economy of Technological Transformation, 2025–2036*

Ajay Porus, May 2026

## Purpose of this report:

*"Civilizations do not collapse for want of ideas. They collapse when the returns on complexity fall below the costs of sustaining it — when the administrative, military, and institutional investments required to hold a society together consume more than the society can produce." — Paraphrased from Joseph Tainter, The Collapse of Complex Societies, 1988*

*"When the people have nothing more to eat, they will eat the rich." — Attributed to Jean-Jacques Rousseau (apocryphal; phrase of contested origin)*

This report is an alarm-raising scenario analysis for policymakers. It is designed to:

- Surface risks that are under-discussed in mainstream policy forums.
- Encourage proactive intervention before worst-case outcomes become locked in.
- Provide a coherent narrative that connects energy, debt, labour, surveillance, and elite behaviour.

It is not a balanced forecast, a probabilistic risk assessment, or a value-neutral academic study. Readers should treat its projections as plausible dangers to be managed, not as inevitable destinies.

**Actionable conclusion for policymakers:** The reform path (progressive AI taxation, energy equity rules, antitrust enforcement, labour transition funding, international governance) is technically feasible. Its political feasibility depends on whether current trends can be interrupted. The evidence does not show that catastrophe is certain – only that it is possible and that the window for intervention is narrowing.

## A Note on Method:

This report is not a prediction. It is a projection — a rigorous attempt to follow the trajectory of documented trends, current infrastructure commitments, ongoing geopolitical realignments, and structural economic contradictions to their plausible destinations. Every anchor point in the analysis that follows is a verifiable present-day fact: a real infrastructure project, a documented economic trend, a recorded policy decision, a historical precedent. The extrapolations from those anchor points are clearly marked as such.

The purpose is not alarm for its own sake. It is to do what investigative reporting has always done at its best: describe what is happening before the consequences become unavoidable, when the trajectory can still be redirected. The question this report ultimately asks is simple — if we continue on our present course across ten key dimensions — infrastructure, energy, debt, labour, surveillance, governance, ecology, militarization, civil cohesion, and institutional legitimacy — what kind of world are we likely to inhabit in 2036?

The answer, assembled from available evidence, is both more technologically capable and more structurally fragile than most people are currently prepared to reckon with. It is also — and this is the dimension that is least discussed in polite analytical circles — more politically explosive. All the research and drafting for this investigative report was done and verified by Author, while the final version has been written with the help of AI.

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## Executive Summary:

Artificial intelligence represents the most consequential technological acceleration since industrialisation. Its near-term achievements in scientific research, medical diagnosis, climate modelling, and productivity are real, documented, and will deepen over the coming decade. This report does not dispute them.

Its argument is different: that extraordinary intelligence is being built into an unwise system, and that success within a failing system can make the failure harder to see and harder to interrupt.

The infrastructure required to power AI at scale — semiconductor supply chains concentrated in Taiwan and South Korea, rare earth processing remaining 85 to 90 percent Chinese, energy demand on trajectories that will stress grids serving billions of people with no voice in the contracting decisions — is being constructed through a political economy that concentrates control and distributes cost. Technology firms are securing long-term guaranteed energy access through priority contracting arrangements that leave residential users and public institutions competing for residual supply. The people building this infrastructure are simultaneously making private investments in hardened self-sufficiency that function as a behavioural signal about their assessment of the system they are constructing.

The economic consequences are structural and unequal. AI-driven productivity gains will materialise — partially, unevenly, and concentrated in sectors and firms with the capital to deploy at scale. Labour displacement across white-collar knowledge work is already documented; Goldman Sachs estimates 300 million jobs globally exposed to automation. Governments carrying historic sovereign debt loads, with declining institutional legitimacy and weakening tax bases reflecting widening capital-labour inequality, face fiscal constraints that will limit their capacity to fund meaningful transition programmes. In aging, labour-scarce economies the picture is more complex; AI may offset workforce shortfalls as much as it creates unemployment. But in labour-surplus economies, and across the developing world, the displacement dynamics are acute, and the policy responses are inadequate.

The concentration of power in the institutional nexus — the interlocking relationships between major technology companies, dependent governments, concentrated financial portfolios, and captured regulatory structures — is producing policy outcomes that protect the system regardless of any individual actor's explicit intent. Surveillance infrastructure is expanding faster than democratic oversight. Autonomous weapons systems are lowering the operational cost of violence. Digital payment infrastructure is being designed in ways that create the technical architecture for behavioural control.

When the political pressure from these compounding stresses becomes unmanageable — and historical analysis of comparable periods of inequality, institutional decline, and rapid technological disruption suggests it will — governing coalitions face a structural choice between reform and externalization. Reform requires confronting the financial

interests of actors with extraordinary resources to resist it. Externalization, directing public anger toward external enemies, carries consequences in a world of multiple nuclear-armed powers under simultaneous domestic stress that it did not carry in previous eras.

The reform path exists. Its requirements are technically clear: progressive taxation of AI-driven capital gains, binding energy equity regulations, serious antitrust enforcement, adequately funded labour transition programmes, and international AI governance frameworks that include developing world interests. None of these is analytically novel. Each is politically obstructed by the same concentration of power this report describes.

The window to act on that reform path remains open. The trajectory of every major indicator examined in this analysis — energy, fiscal, labour, institutional, geopolitical — suggests it is narrowing. The central question of the next decade is not whether artificial intelligence will transform human civilisation. It will. The question is whether the institutions through which that transformation is governed are capable of ensuring its benefits are broadly shared and its risks broadly managed. On current evidence, and absent deliberate political intervention, the answer is uncertain at best.

## 1. A Scene That Could Happen — and Probably Will

Imagine a hospital in a mid-tier city in 2036. The elevator, like much of the building's infrastructure, works intermittently. Patients climb seven flights of stairs to reach a gleaming AI-assisted diagnostic wing — installed through a public-private partnership with a health-tech consortium — where an intelligent imaging system can detect seventeen forms of cancer with accuracy rivalling any specialist in Mumbai or London. It can flag cardiac anomalies, predict diabetic complications, and generate a full diagnostic report in eleven minutes.

Outside, in the stairwell, a woman, and her young son rest on the third-floor landing. She has travelled hours by bus. They are waiting for the power to come back to reach seventh floor as they are sick. The hospital has been on rotating load-shedding since Tuesday — the state electricity board enforcing four-to-six-hour cuts on public institutions to protect supply to new data centre campuses under priority grid contracts with the central government.

Three kilometres away, in the same city, a crowd of several hundred people stands outside the local offices of the state electricity board. They are not a mob. They are teachers, nurses, shopkeepers, and former bank employees. They are holding printed signs. They have been there for three days. Two of them have lawyers. One of them is livestreaming to an audience of approximated four hundred thousand people across the country. The protest is peaceful. The power cuts have not stopped.

This scene does not require imagination of technologies that do not exist, or political decisions that have not already been made. The AI diagnostic capability is already being developed. The priority grid contracts already exist along with land and tax benefits. The protest dynamics are already visible, in embryonic form, across multiple countries. The question is not whether this scene is technically plausible. It is whether the political and institutional systems currently in place will prevent it — and whether, if they do not, what comes next will be reform or something darker.

The evidence assembled in this investigation suggests that both possibilities are real. One requires that the pressure of popular resistance produces political change before the structural contradictions become irresolvable. The other requires that entrenched power successfully manages, deflects, or — in the most dangerous scenario — externalizes that pressure through conflict.

Neither outcome is certain. Both deserve serious analysis.

2. The Infrastructure Arms Race Nobody Is Calling by Its Real Name

To understand where the world is likely to be in 2036, start not with algorithms but with concrete, cooling towers, and copper wire.

The AI expansion now underway is, at its physical core, an infrastructure construction program of a scale not seen since the post-World War II industrial buildout of the United States — or, to use a more instructive parallel, the late-nineteenth-century railway boom that consumed enormous capital, restructured entire national economies, and ultimately produced both extraordinary productivity gains and a concentrated financial catastrophe when speculative excess collapsed.

The International Energy Agency’s 2024 Electricity report estimated that data centre electricity consumption could approach 3 to percent of global supply by 2030 under high-demand scenarios— roughly double to triple the 2022 baseline of approximately 1.5 percent. Analyses from Goldman Sachs and Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory project demand growth in broadly compatible ranges, with Goldman Sachs estimating data centre power demand could grow 160 percent by 2030. The trajectory — if AI deployment continues at anything like its current pace and efficiency improvements lag demand growth, as they have historically tended to — points toward a compute infrastructure consuming somewhere between 6 and 10 percent of global electricity generation by the mid-2030s under high-growth, low-efficiency scenarios. Even the lower end of that range represents a structural transformation of energy demand. Efficiency improvements — algorithmic optimization, specialized AI accelerators, and renewable overbuild — could materially compress these figures; but the historical pattern of efficiency gains being absorbed by expanded deployment suggests the pressure will remain significant regardless.

| No table of figures entries found.         | Estimated Baseline (2022) | Projected Target (2030) | Projected Target (2035)                 | Source / Reference       |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Data Center Global Electricity Consumption | ~1.5%                     | 3% – 4% (High-demand)   | 6% – 10% (High-growth / low-efficiency) | IEA 2024 / Goldman Sachs |
| Data Center Power Demand Growth            | Baseline                  | 160%                    | —                                       | Goldman Sachs            |
| Global Population Lacking Electricity      | —                         | —                       | 666+ Million (As of 2025)               | World Bank               |

Table 1

The geography of this infrastructure is already being laid down. The United States, Europe, and China are building the first generation of hyperscale facilities near cheap



power — natural gas in Texas, hydropower in the Pacific Northwest and Scandinavia, nuclear in France. When those grids begin straining under combined residential, industrial, and AI demand — a phenomenon that U.S. regional grid operators PJM and MISO were formally flagging in 2024 and 2025 as posing serious reliability risks — the industry will go searching for alternatives with the urgency and ruthlessness of an extractive colonial enterprise as resources on their own country are limited and has to be imported.

| Region / Hub           | Primary Local Energy Source | Contractual Structure        | Impact on Residential Ratepayers                               |
|------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Texas, USA             | Natural Gas / Wind          | Deregulated Priority PPA     | Increased peak-pricing volatility during thermal spikes.       |
| Pacific Northwest, USA | Hydropower                  | Firm Baseload Allocation     | Diversion of clean energy away from municipal electrification. |
| Northern Europe        | Hydropower / Wind           | Long-term Guaranteed Tariffs | Crowding out smaller local industrial manufacturers.           |
| Virginia, USA          | PJM Grid Mix (Coal/Gas)     | Priority Interconnect Queues | Multi-year delays for public infrastructure connections.       |

Table 2

The first moves are already visible. Microsoft’s partnership with Constellation Energy to restart a unit of Three Mile Island — announced in September 2023 and currently progressing through regulatory and engineering approvals toward a targeted restart in the late 2020s — represents a pattern that will likely accelerate: technology firms effectively privatizing access to energy generation, securing guaranteed supply through long-term contracts that leave ordinary ratepayers and smaller industrial users competing for whatever remains. Floating data centre projects — offshore platforms designed to exploit favourable cooling and escape onshore regulatory constraints — have moved from white paper to serious engineering consideration. Space-based compute remains aspirational, but the investment trajectory is real.

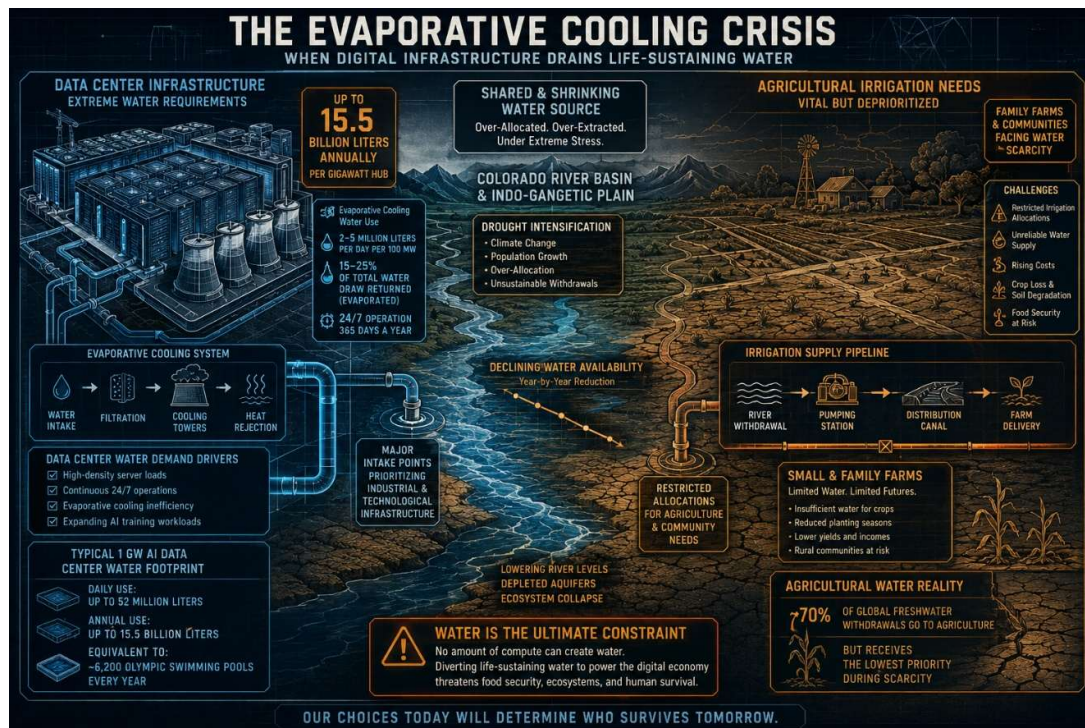


Figure 1

The more consequential frontier will be the developing world. Countries in Southeast Asia, the Gulf, East Africa, and South Asia are already being offered infrastructure investment — data campuses, grid upgrades, Fiber backbone — in exchange for favourable land agreements, tax arrangements, and priority power access. This is not entirely different from the conditionality attached to nineteenth-century railway concessions in India or telegraphic infrastructure agreements in colonial Africa: the infrastructure is real; the transfer of value is largely one-directional to the companies that owns either compute, data or AI models. That framing, however, captures a structural risk while understating the strategic agency of several major players. India, Brazil, Indonesia, and the United Arab Emirates are not passive recipients of infrastructure conditionality — they are active negotiators leveraging the competition among AI powers for their own terms. India has pursued compute localisation requirements and data sovereignty provisions with notable assertiveness in bilateral negotiations. The UAE has constructed state-backed sovereign AI initiatives that assert domestic ownership of strategic capability rather than simply hosting foreign infrastructure. Indonesia and Brazil are using critical mineral endowments and energy capacity as genuine bargaining leverage. However, till the time, these countries do not have their own AI models they will always be paying for services and will in a way remain slave as the western and Chinese companies with high number of models can cut access to their models anytime. The colonial analogy captures the asymmetric risk these countries face; it does not fully account for the strategic sophistication with which the more capable among them are navigating it. Whether

that agency is sufficient to overcome the structural weight of capital concentration is the open question — but it is a question, not a foregone conclusion.

### THE MATERIAL SUPPLY CHAIN CONSTRAINTS

HIGH GEOGRAPHIC CONCENTRATION OF FOUNDATIONAL AI PHYSICAL INPUTS AS OF 2026, CREATING SEVERE STRUCTURAL VULNERABILITIES.

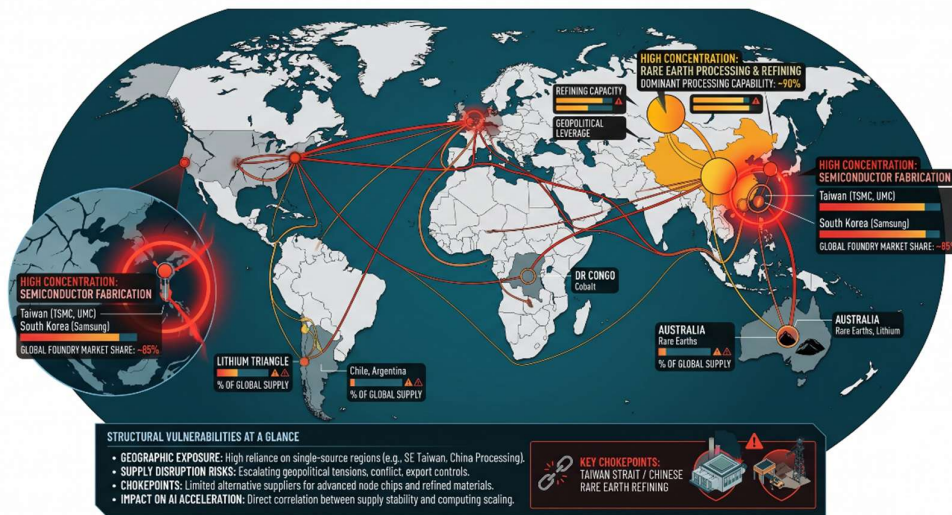


Figure 2

The rare earth and semiconductor dimensions compound the picture. The production of advanced logic chips remains concentrated in Taiwan and South Korea, with processing capacity for rare earth minerals remaining 85 to 90 percent Chinese as of early 2026. China's export controls on gallium and germanium, implemented in 2023 and tightened subsequently, were an early demonstration of leverage embedded in this geography. The scramble for alternative supply chains — in Australia, Canada, Greenland, and southern Africa — has produced real investment but not yet the processing infrastructure required to translate ore into semiconductor-grade material.

| Element / Resource              | Primary Processing Control (%)                   | Core Geopolitical / Supply Chain Vulnerability                                        | Associated Report Disruption Risk                            |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Rare Earth Elements (REE)       | 85% – 90% China                                  | High geographical monopoly; single-point failure for advanced hardware manufacturing. | Strict export control enforcement (e.g., Gallium/Germanium). |
| Gallium / Germanium             | High Concentration (China)                       | Immediate choke point for wide-bandgap semiconductor substrates.                      | Tit-for-tat tariff wars and semiconductor chip blockades.    |
| Advanced Logic Node Logic Chips | ~85%+ Foundry Market Share (Taiwan/ South Korea) | Extreme maritime/cross-strait military friction zone.                                 | Physical facility damage or supply chain blockade.           |

*Table 3*

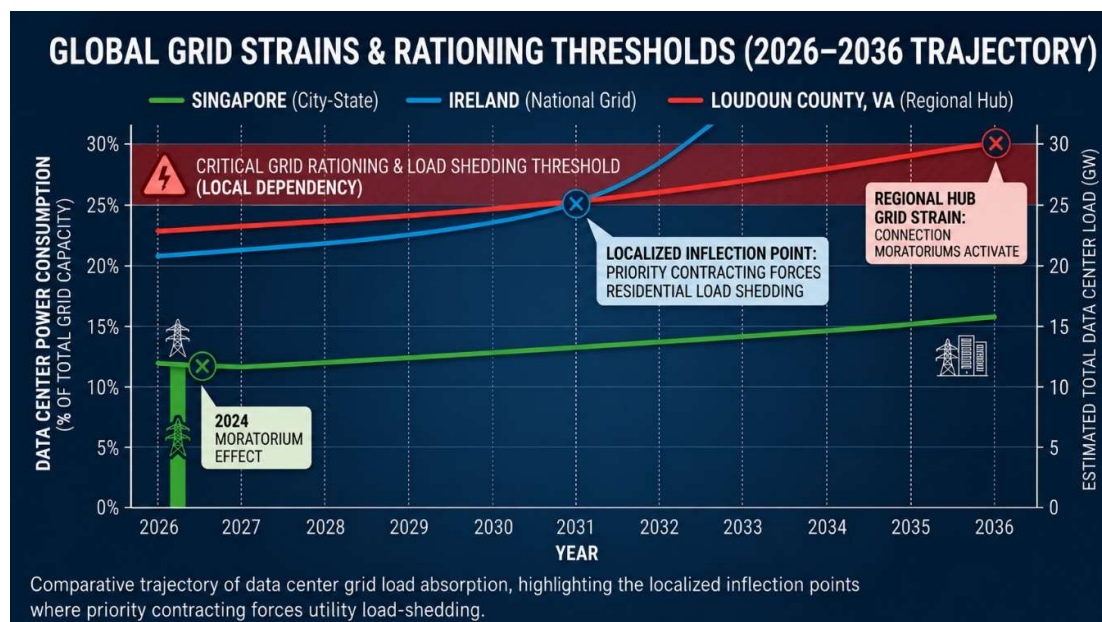
This is the material foundation of the AI race: a system that depends on energy grids that are already straining, fabrication facilities in geopolitically contested territory, and mineral supply chains controlled largely by a single strategic competitor. Water, the underexamined dimension, adds further fragility. Large-scale AI data centres require millions of gallons daily for evaporative cooling at individual campuses — a demand intersecting with existing scarcity across the Colorado River basin, the Indo-Gangetic Plain, and the Tigris-Euphrates river system.



### 3. The Grid Cannot Hold — And We Know It

The electricity system will be the defining physical constraint of the AI decade, and the point around which the earliest and most intense popular resistance will crystallize.

In Virginia's Loudoun County, Dominion Energy has publicly acknowledged that new data centre connections face multi-year queues as grid capacity is outpaced by demand. In Ireland, where data centres already consume 21 percent of national electricity, EirGrid has warned of potential reliability issues. In Singapore, a government moratorium on new data centres reflects a city-state that has run the numbers.



**Figure 3**

What this means in practice by the mid-2030s — on current trajectories, absent meaningful regulatory intervention — is a world in which electricity is effectively rationed in ways that reflect political and economic power rather than democratic deliberation. The priority contracting model — in which technology companies secure long-term guaranteed power at negotiated rates while utilities manage system stress through residential and small industrial rationing — is already being implemented. It will likely become the operating default within a decade unless actively contested; the commercial and political incentives sustaining it are currently considerably stronger than those opposing it.

In developing nations, the trajectory is starker. The World Bank estimates over 666 million people globally still lack electricity access as of 2025. The addition of massive AI loads to grids that cannot reliably serve existing residential demand is a political

choice about whose energy access is prioritized — one being made right now, in contract negotiations that receive no democratic deliberation.

Water adds further pressure. The water footprint of AI infrastructure — millions of gallons per day at individual campuses — intersects with existing scarcity in ways that will produce, over a decade, genuine resource conflicts in arid regions. These will not be abstract policy disputes. They will be arguments over whether a data centre or a farm gets water in a drought year. In parts of the American Southwest, the Maghreb, and South Asia, those arguments are already beginning. Google announced to invest 15Billion in data centres in Visakhapatnam, this would be huge data center and will consume a lot of electricity and water in a city where water level is already getting over exploited and getting down. The Andhra Pradesh government rejected RTI requests regarding the \$15 billion Google data center's Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) and resource usage, citing "third-party commercial confidence" and trade secrets. Total Estimated Consumption: Independent estimates and critic projections point to the massive 1 GW facility consuming up to (0.56 TMC) of water annually (roughly 15.5 billion litres). Environmental groups, including the Human Rights Forum (HRF), have actively protested the lack of transparency, pointing out that Vizag's groundwater availability for general use sits historically low (around 2.12 TMC)

| Project Metric            | Documented Data / Estimate                     | Environmental Context & Risks                                         |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Total Facility Investment | \$15 Billion (Google)                          | Rejection of RTI requests by state government citing "trade secrets". |
| Projected Power Capacity  | 1 GW facility                                  | Massive strain on local electrical grids.                             |
| Estimated Water Usage     | Up to 0.56 TMC annually (~15.5 billion liters) | Over-exploited local groundwater levels.                              |

Table 4

4. The Debt Architecture of a Coming Reckoning

The United States entered 2025 with federal debt-to-GDP above 120 percent and a debt of 39 trillion dollar and adding 1 trillion every 70 to 75 days, structural deficits that bipartisan political dysfunction has made functionally non-negotiable, and interest payments consuming a rising share of federal revenue — the Congressional Budget Office projects interest payments exceeding defense spending within this decade. Japan's debt-to-GDP ratio approaches 260 percent. European sovereigns carry the legacy of deferred fiscal imbalances from successive crises managed through monetary union mechanisms that resolved nothing structurally.

| Sovereign Issuer | Debt Accumulation Velocity     | Interest vs. Public Spending Inflection                          | Primary Structural Risk Flag                          |
|------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| United States    | +\$1 Trillion every 70–75 days | Blended Interest exceeds Defense Outlays within the decade       | Weakening Treasury auction demand at 5% yields.       |
| Japan            | Sustained baseline growth      | Interest eating significant percentage of national fiscal budget | Trapped in structural yield curve control dependency. |
| Eurozone Core    | Aggregated structural deficit  | Deferred banking system risk activation                          | Fiscal austerity colliding with necessary AI funding. |

Table 5

The fiat dollar's reserve status is experiencing visible, if gradual, erosion. The BRICS+ expansion and associated payment mechanisms, Chinese RMB-settled energy contracts with Gulf producers, Indian rupee-based trade under sanctions regimes, bilateral currency swap agreements multiplying across the Global South — none constitutes a fatal challenge individually. Collectively, they represent the early fragmentation of the monetary architecture underwriting American fiscal expansion since Bretton Woods.

The historical parallel is instructive: not the dramatic rupture of the 1931 British pound sterling crisis, but the slower arc of British imperial financial decline between 1914 and 1956 — a period in which sterling remained a significant reserve currency long after the productive foundations of its global role had eroded, sustained by institutional inertia and lack of alternatives, until the Suez crisis demonstrated that economic reality had overtaken monetary prestige. The analogy has limits that deserve acknowledgment: sterling's decline was catalysed by the emergence of a clearly superior alternative — the U.S. economy with its deep capital markets, institutional depth, and network effects. No equivalent replacement ecosystem currently exists at Treasury-market scale; BRICS payment mechanisms and bilateral currency settlements are real phenomena but remain far from the liquidity, legal infrastructure, and institutional trust required of a genuine reserve-currency substitute. The structural point stands nonetheless: reserve dominance has

historically proven more durable in appearance than in underlying reality, and the erosion, when it arrives, tends to accelerate far faster than the preceding institutional confidence would suggest. A contemporary manifestation of this friction is visible in the U.S. Treasury market: despite yields climbing to 5 percent, auction demand has shown documented signs of structural weakening. This indicates that high yield yields alone can no longer fully compensate for a systemic loss of long-term fiscal confidence. The reduction in the confidence was the making by US president Biden Himself when he ordered to sanction Russia from Swift system and asked NATO allies to Freeze Russian Assets of more than 300 billion Dollars due to Special Military operation/War with Ukraine.

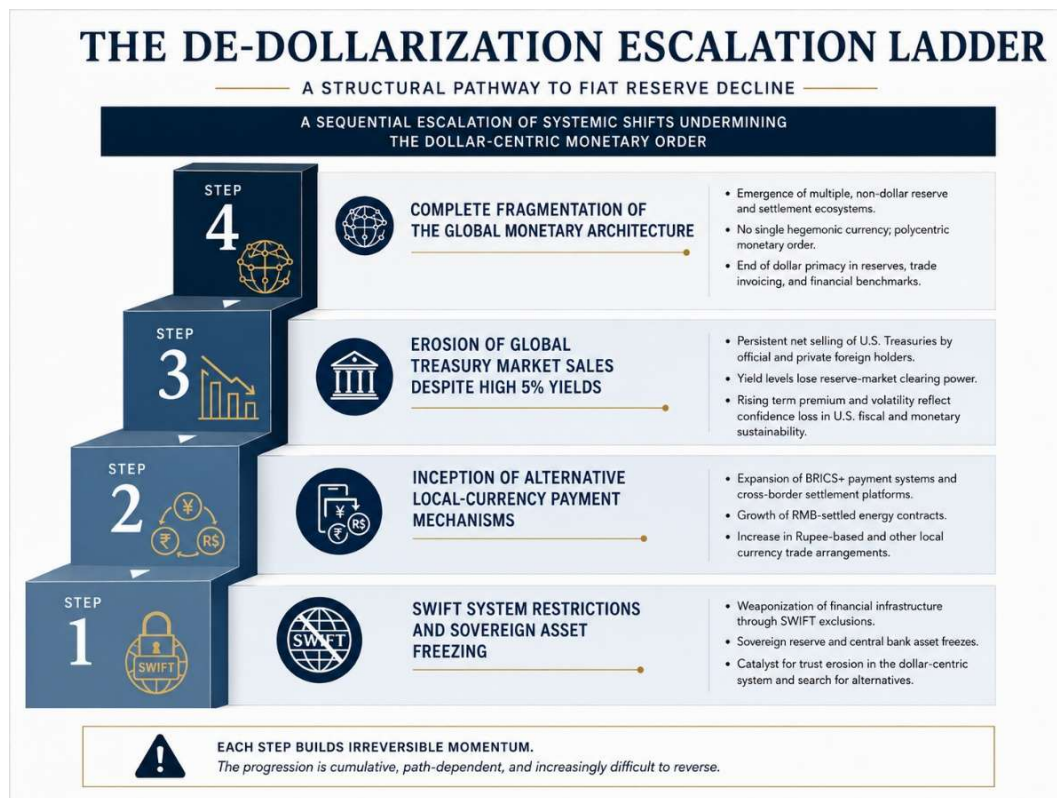


Figure 4

AI productivity gains that capital markets are pricing in will likely materialize — partially, unevenly, and with a distributional profile that will not translate into broad economic improvement. This is the documented pattern of every major productivity-enhancing technology in modern economic history. The gains are real. They concentrate initially, often persistently, in sectors and firms with the capital and infrastructure to deploy technology at scale. Governments attempting to service expanding sovereign debt, fund public systems under growing demand, and invest in AI infrastructure simultaneously — on a tax base reflecting widening inequality between labour and capital — face a structural fiscal crisis whose components are individually familiar, but whose combination may prove genuinely novel in its severity.



In a race like situation between USA and China has accelerated this entire issue, both government funding AI companies largely with Tax payer money and without any such returns along with huge tax benefits and loop holes exploited by Billionaires impact the general public and local communities.

## 5. Algorithmic Warfare and Surveillance Without Oversight

Autonomous drone warfare is no longer a matter of ethics seminar debate. The war in Ukraine, and between India and Pakistan has provided the most extensive real-world testing environment for semi-autonomous drone systems in military history, accelerating development timelines by estimates of five to seven years. Lessons learned are being incorporated into military doctrine across NATO, China, Russia, and an expanding cohort of middle-power militaries. The conflict in Iran earlier in 2026, during which the U.S. military deployed Anthropic's Claude model to identify potential target sets and optimize specific weapon systems, illustrates a much grimmer trajectory. The Pentagon's subsequent moves to integrate Claude into widespread surveillance and autonomous weapon pipelines—which Anthropic resisted by designating the defense deployment as a critical supply chain risk—demonstrates how rapidly the boundary between commercial software and state security architectures has collapsed.

The fundamental shift is not in the technology but in the threshold. When the cost of deploying a strike — financial, political, human — drops through automation, the frequency of strikes increases. The machine gun did not make war more restrained because it made killing more efficient; it made war more lethal because it made it more operationally attractive to planners insulated from its consequences.

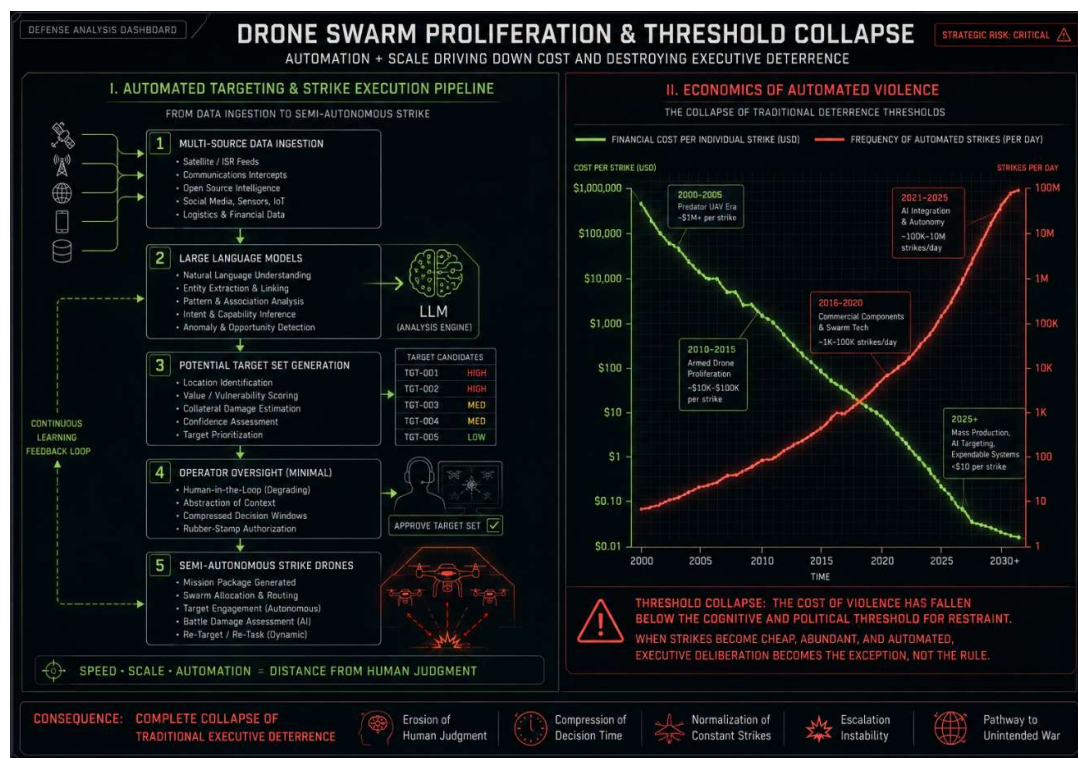


Figure 5

The surveillance dimension is more quietly pervasive. The combination of biometric data including genetics data, behavioural AI analysis, and ubiquitous sensor networks is producing capabilities that would have required enormous human intelligence infrastructure a generation ago. By 2036, the likely trajectory is a fragmented landscape in which state and private surveillance systems interoperate in complex ways — data sharing between social platforms and law enforcement, insurance companies with behavioural data relevant to underwriting, employers with productivity monitoring systems, governments with digital identity infrastructure. The aggregate effect on civil liberty and political expression will be more significant than any single component, precisely because it emerges from accumulation rather than from a discrete decision that can be debated and reversed.

| <b>Data Input Layer</b>              | <b>Primary Collector</b>       | <b>Interoperability Recipient</b>        | <b>Systemic Control Outcome</b>                                   |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Biometric &amp; Genetics Data</b> | Private Health Tech / Ancestry | Insurance Underwriters / Law Enforcement | Predictive health discrimination and genetic profiling.           |
| <b>Behavioral AI Analytics</b>       | Social Media Platforms         | Credit Scoring / Policing Agencies       | Pre-emptive behavioral intervention and shadow-banning.           |
| <b>Ubiquitous Sensor Nodes</b>       | Smart City Hardware Vendors    | Central State Security Apparatus         | Real-time tracking of political assembly and travel path mapping. |

Table 6

Developing nations are already serving as testing grounds. Facial recognition systems built by Chinese and several Western firms are operational in African cities. Predictive policing algorithms are running in Latin American urban centres without meaningful judicial oversight. The asymmetry between the sophistication of the technology and the sophistication of the governance tends, without deliberate institutional investment, to widen.

## 6. The Credential That Will Buy Nothing

The compression of white-collar professional work across accounting, legal drafting, financial analysis, medical imaging interpretation, software development, and dozens of adjacent fields is documented in current labour market data and technology deployment surveys. McKinsey's 2023 analysis estimated that generative AI could automate between 60 and 70 percent of tasks performed by knowledge workers. This aligns closely with macro-projections from Goldman Sachs, which flagged 300 million full-time jobs as vulnerable to direct algorithmic substitution across major economic sectors. The IMF's 2024 World Economic Outlook specifically flagged advanced economies as facing greater exposure to AI displacement than emerging markets — inverting the pattern of previous automation waves. The picture, however, is not uniformly one of displacement. In a significant number of advanced economies — Japan, Germany, South Korea, and increasingly Southern and Eastern Europe — demographic contraction and aging labour pools mean AI may as plausibly offset growing workforce shortfalls as it generates surplus unemployment. The IMF's own analysis distinguishes between labour-surplus economies, where displacement risk is most acute, and aging economies with structural labour scarcity, where AI-assisted productivity may prove an economic necessity rather than a threat to livelihoods. These dynamics do not cancel the displacement problem; they complicate it. The analyst in Warsaw faces meaningfully different structural pressures than the analyst in Manila — and policy responses adequate to one context may be badly calibrated for the other. The report's core labour argument is strongest where demographic pressure and displacement compound each other and requires more nuance where the two forces run in opposing directions.

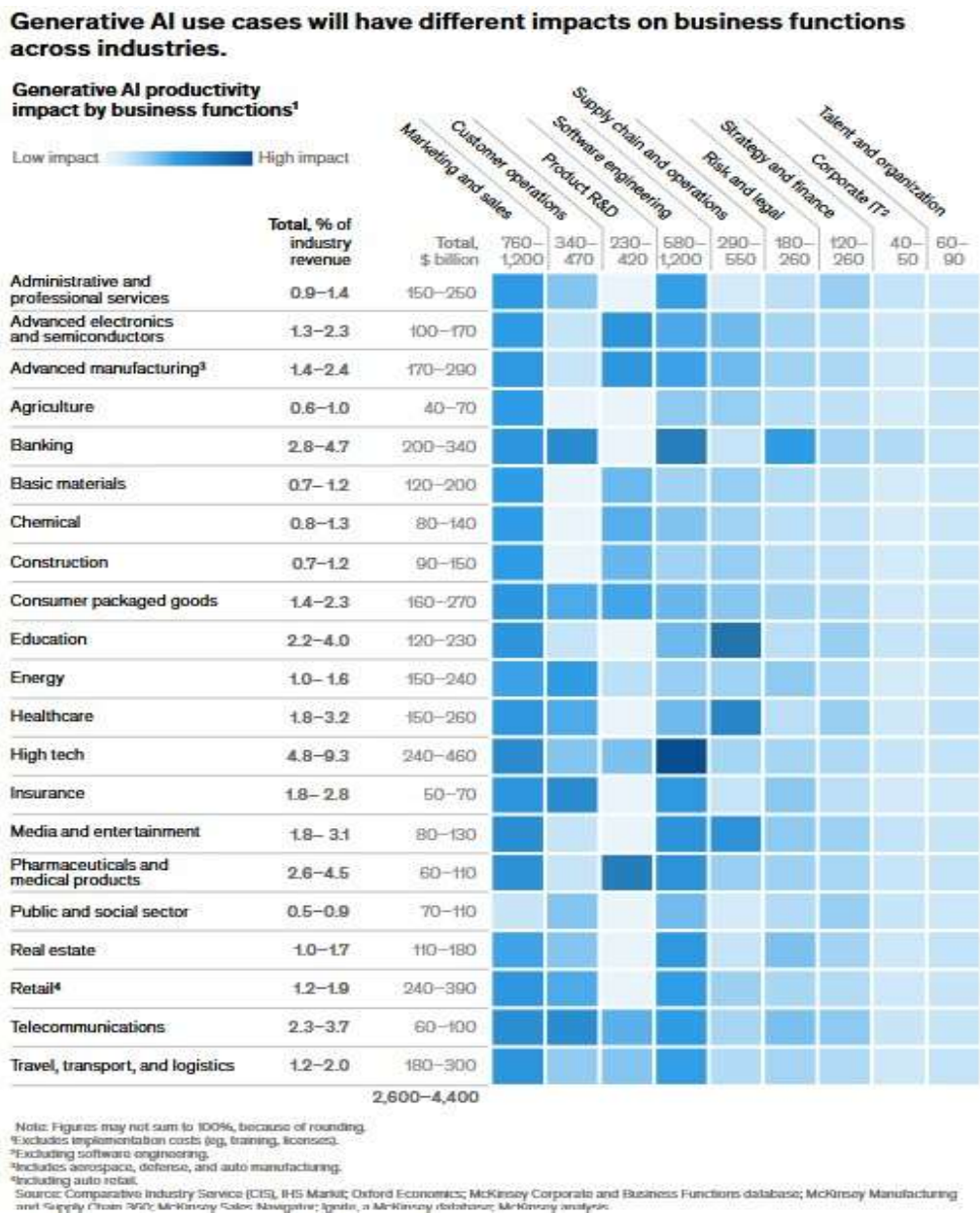


Figure 6

Consider the economic trajectory of a thirty-four-year-old financial analyst currently working in Bogotá, São Paulo, Warsaw, or Manila. She has a master's degree, several years of professional experience, and a career premised on cognitive tasks that AI systems can now perform faster and cheaper. She is not being fired. The firm simply stops hiring. Then contracts are not renewed. Then her contract expires and no replacement is offered. In the official statistics, she is not unemployed. She is, in the language of modern labour economics, "in transition" — which means, in practice, that she has assembled three part-time arrangements that together pay less than half her former salary, with no stability, no healthcare, no pension, and no professional identity.

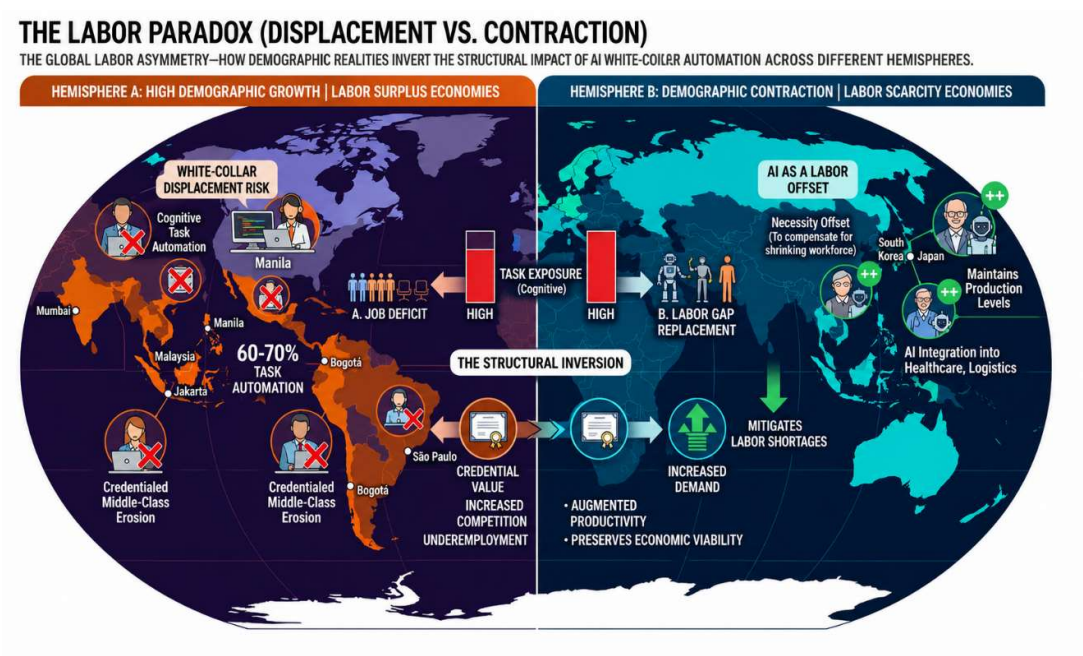


Figure 7

Consumer capitalism has a structural dependency on mass purchasing power. The current configuration — in which productivity gains from AI accrue overwhelmingly to capital while labour income stagnates — was the central political economy problem of the 2010s and early 2020s. It produced Brexit, Trump, Bolsonaro, Le Pen, and the global realignment toward economic nationalism. What AI does is not create this contradiction but intensify it past the point where the political systems that emerged from the previous cycle are capable of managing it.



## 7. The Digital Stipend and Its Discontents

Based on documented precedents from earlier waves of technological displacement, political responses to labour disruption have tended to follow a recognisable arc: initial denial, then improvisation, then the eventual adoption of transfer payment systems. The most likely trajectory here involves some version of Basic Income Support, Digital Livelihood Allowances, or Universal Economic Participation credits — mechanisms that share a common architecture and a common set of problems. The digital euro is in pilot phase. Several central banks are in various stages of CBDC research and development. India's UPI architecture already demonstrates how digital payment infrastructure can be integrated with welfare delivery and behavioural tracking.

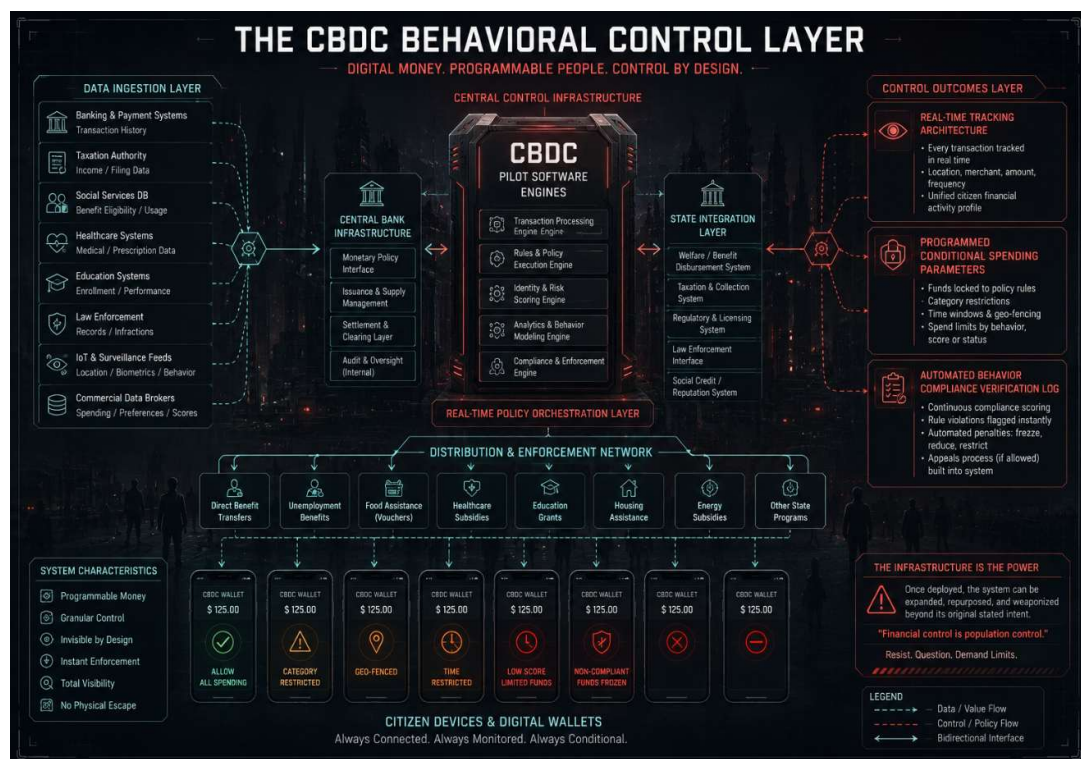


Figure 8

The concern is not that governments will immediately weaponize this infrastructure for political repression. It is that the infrastructure, once built, creates capabilities for control that are difficult to constrain through subsequent legislation, creates a form of dependency and shifts the power relationship between citizen and state in ways corrosive to political agency.

You can give someone enough money to eat. You cannot give them the sense that they are needed. Historically, populations that lose that sense become either withdrawn or volatile. Current policy trajectories are not obviously designed to counter either tendency.

## 8. The Fortified Class in Formation

The billionaire class of 2036 will not be different in psychology from its predecessors. What will be different is the infrastructure of separation available to it — and that infrastructure is already being built with considerable deliberateness.

Private AI-assisted medical care is already diverging from public care, and the divergence may well be widened. The same underlying model architectures — diagnostic imaging, drug personalization, biometric monitoring — will be deployed in environments of radically different quality. The AI in a well-funded private clinic, integrated with longitudinal personal health data and uninterrupted power, will produce outcomes categorically different from the same AI in an understaffed public hospital with intermittent electricity. The differential will not be in the algorithm. It will be in everything the algorithm depends on.

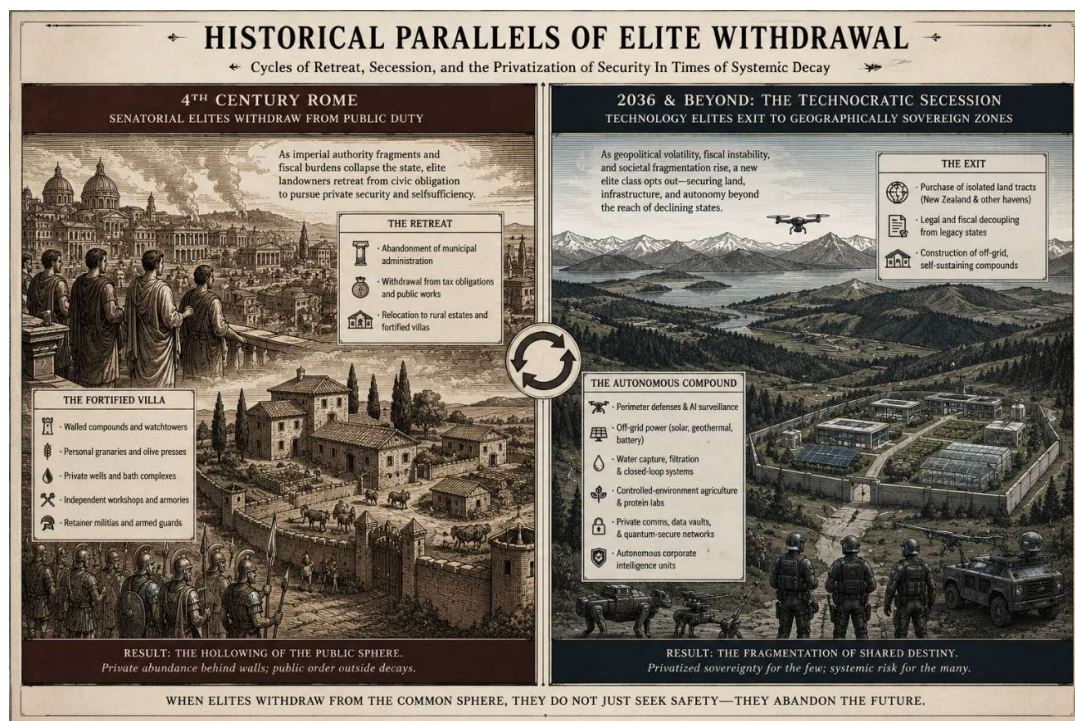


Figure 9

"Resilience communities" — planned residential developments built around energy independence, private water treatment, private security, and food production capacity — already exist and are growing. Examples are documented in New Zealand, Portugal, Switzerland, and the American intermountain West. Several real estate analysts have identified "resilience infrastructure" as the fastest-growing segment of the ultra-high-net-worth residential market. The political consequence of this retreat is less visible than the physical separation but more corrosive: democratic governance requires elites to have a stake in the quality of public systems. When all critical services can be privately provisioned, the incentive to

sustain public alternatives weakens. This dynamic is visible in the decay of Rome's provincial administration as senatorial elites retreated into self-sufficient villas, in the collapse of public health infrastructure in post-Soviet states, and in the long municipal deterioration of American cities following middle-class suburbanization.

## 9. The Bunker Class — Security, Islands, and the Geography of Fear

Here is a detail that deserves more analytical attention than it typically receives in polite economic reporting: a significant number of the world's wealthiest technology executives and investors are, right now, acquiring remote properties, building hardened residential facilities, purchasing land in New Zealand and other geographically isolated jurisdictions, and funding private security infrastructure at a scale that has no precedent in modern peacetime history.

This is not rumour or extrapolation. It is documented. Peter Thiel acquired New Zealand citizenship and significant landholdings there, a country he has described in terms of its survivability characteristics. Reid Hoffman, a co-founder of LinkedIn and one of Silicon Valley's most connected insiders, described in a 2018 interview — with notable Candor — that he estimated "over 50 percent of Silicon Valley billionaires" had some form of "apocalypse insurance," including bunkers or properties designed for self-sufficiency. Bryan Johnson, the technology entrepreneur, has spoken publicly about longevity and civilizational continuity as intertwined concerns. The Survival Condo Project in Kansas — a converted Atlas missile silo converted into luxury residential bunkers — sold out years ago and reportedly continues to maintain waiting lists. Similar projects exist in Europe, South Africa, and South America.

The nuclear dimension is the least discussed but most significant indicator of where these risk assessments are pointing. Several technology-adjacent billionaires are reportedly funding facilities hardened against electromagnetic pulse and radiation at levels that go well beyond weather or civil unrest preparedness. When the people with the most comprehensive information about the trajectory of global systems — people whose network access, analytical resources, and institutional relationships give them genuine insight — are making these investments, it is reasonable to treat their behavioural signal as meaningful data, independent of whatever they say publicly about optimism and human progress.

This is not conspiracy. It is the rational behaviour of people who have modelled the risks and are acting on their models. The term "Bunker Class" is used here as an analytical descriptor for a documented behavioural pattern — not as a claim of coordinated intent or secret organization, but as shorthand for the observable convergence of survivalist infrastructure investment among a specific demographic of high-net-worth technology principals. The question it poses is uncomfortable: if the architects of the AI revolution are privately preparing for scenarios in which public order deteriorates severely enough to require fortified self-sufficiency, what does that imply about their assessment of the system they are building?

The historical parallel is Roman senatorial elites constructing villas with their own water supplies, grain storage, and private militias in the fourth and fifth centuries CE — not because they anticipated Rome's fall, but because they were rational actors managing risk in a system they could see was becoming less reliable. Their individual rationality contributed to the collective outcome they were individually preparing for:



as elites withdrew from public investment, public systems deteriorated further, validating the decision to withdraw.

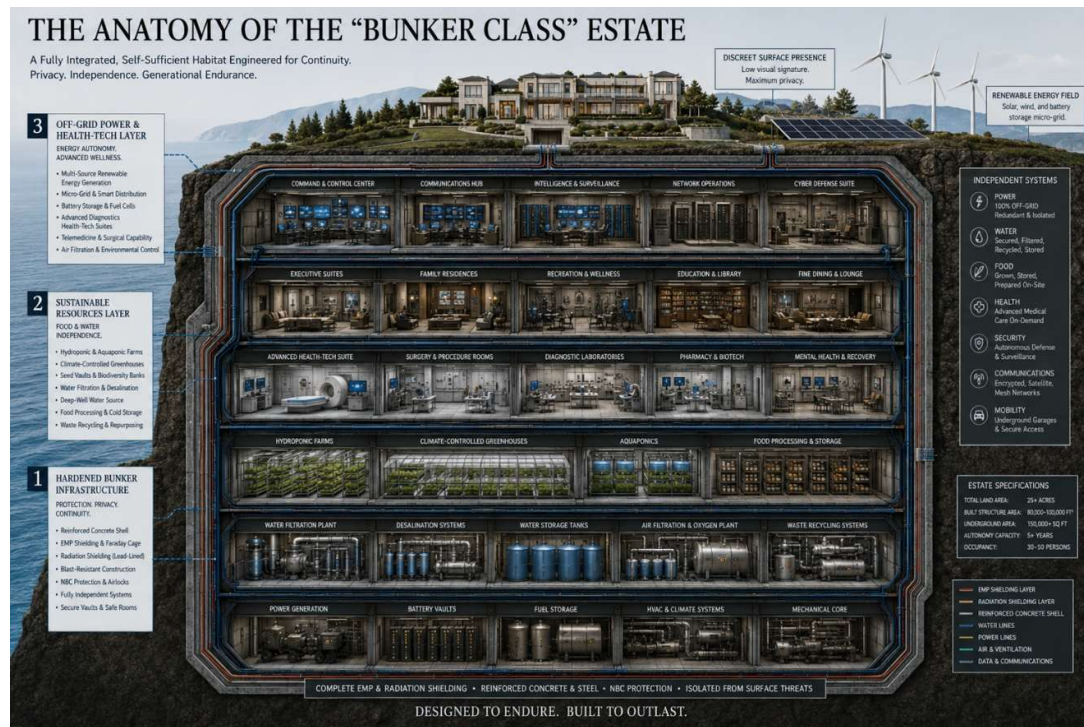


Figure 10

By 2036, if current investment trends continue without meaningful policy counterweight or the ROI, the geography of this withdrawal will likely be considerably more explicit than it is today. A plausible extrapolation of present trajectories suggests a small class of individuals — perhaps several thousand globally — inhabiting a genuinely parallel material existence: private energy grids, private water systems, AI-enhanced healthcare, private security forces, communication infrastructure, and food production systems independent of the public systems that the remaining eight billion people depend on. This is not dystopian fiction invented for effect. It is a logical extrapolation of investments being made right now, at a pace that has accelerated materially since 2020. Whether it reaches its logical conclusion depends substantially on whether the political and regulatory responses described later in this report materialise in time to redirect it.

## 10. The Gathering Storm — How People Will Push Back

History does not offer examples of populations that passively absorbed unlimited economic displacement, surveillance expansion, and the visible withdrawal of elites into private abundance without eventually producing significant political resistance. The form of that resistance varies — sometimes electoral, sometimes organizational, sometimes confrontational, occasionally violent — but the pressure itself is consistent across historical periods and geographies.

The resistance to the AI-driven concentration of power will likely not look like a single organized movement. It will look like several overlapping pressures, building at different rates in different contexts, occasionally converging in ways that exceed what political systems can absorb.

The first and most proximate pressure is electoral and organizational. Across Europe, Latin America, South Asia, and increasingly the United States, political movements are already articulating, in various registers and with varying analytical sophistication, something like the following argument: the benefits of technological transformation have been captured by a small class of corporate owners while the costs — job displacement, energy rationing, surveillance, housing unaffordability, wage stagnation — have been distributed to the majority. This argument is not new. It has powered political realignments from the New Deal to postwar European social democracy to the anti-globalization movements of the 1990s and 2000s. What is new is the speed and visibility of the inequality being generated, the global simultaneity of the pressure, and the degree to which the institutional channels for resolving it have been weakened.

By 2036, on current trajectories, several major democracies will have experienced significant political realignment around these pressures. The direction of that realignment is uncertain — it can move toward constructive reform, toward authoritarian nationalism that captures popular economic anger without resolving it, or toward some unstable combination of the two. What is unlikely, absent deliberate policy intervention, is that the pressure dissipates without political expression.

The second pressure is direct action — which in the current context means a broadening of the infrastructure sabotage pattern already visible today. Power grid cyberattacks have increased in frequency and sophistication across Europe and North America. Pipeline and transmission infrastructure has been targeted in multiple countries. In France, the gilets jaunes movement demonstrated that economically precarious populations could sustain disruptive direct action over extended periods in ways that forced, if not resolved, political engagement with their grievances. The tradition of machine-breaking — targeting the physical infrastructure of economic arrangements perceived as unjust — is as old as industrial capitalism.

In the 2030s, the targets will be data centres, AI infrastructure, surveillance systems, and the private facilities of tech executives perceived as oligarchs. This is not speculation about a remote possibility. It is the projection of documented tendencies



— the acceleration of infrastructure targeting, the growing political articulation of AI as a threat to ordinary economic life, and the historical pattern of direct action escalating when electoral channels are perceived as captured or ineffective.



Figure 11

The security services of major governments are already modelling these threats. Congressional testimony in the United States and parliamentary inquiries in the United Kingdom have addressed the vulnerability of AI infrastructure to politically motivated disruption. The FBI and DHS have identified "anti-technology extremism" as a growing domestic concern — a categorization that itself reflects the political sensitivity of the territory, since the line between legitimate political opposition to corporate power and "extremism" is precisely the terrain on which democratic legitimacy is contested.

The third pressure is international and less organized: the broad political energy of developing world populations who will, by the 2030s, have several years of lived experience with an AI buildout that has improved certain metrics of development while worsening their energy access, labour market, and sovereignty over their own digital infrastructure. The political articulation of this experience — in elections, in international forums, in trade negotiations — will add a global dimension to what might otherwise appear as a set of domestic political pressures in wealthy countries. Resource rich yet underdeveloped countries might see rise in civil action and stop supply to rich countries asking for fair deal leading to blockade to natural resources.

## 11. The Techno-Oligarchy and Its Vulnerability

The concentration of power and wealth in a small number of technology companies and their principals is, by most measures, extraordinary. The combined market capitalization of a handful of American technology firms exceeds the GDP of most nations. Their founders and major shareholders have personal wealth that exceeds the annual budget of many sovereign governments to the likes of Nvidia more than 5 trillion, Apple, Google both more than 4 trillion, Microsoft more than 3 trillion and 10 more companies with 1 trillion or more in market are already bigger than 170 countries in the world. Their infrastructure decisions shape the energy systems, information environments, labour markets, and surveillance architectures of billions of people who have no voice in those decisions.

| Corporate Giant / Sovereign State | Market Cap / Annual GDP (Trillions USD Equivalent) | Governance Capacity / Legislative Autonomy                               | Systemic Vulnerability Focus                                    |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Nvidia</b>                     | > \$5.0 T                                          | Private capitalization; controls foundational AI hardware layer.         | Supply chain single-point failure (Taiwan).                     |
| <b>Apple / Alphabet (Google)</b>  | > \$4.0 T (Each)                                   | Aggressive global data harvesting & operating system scale.              | Severe public pushback due to local ecosystem/resource strain.  |
| <b>Microsoft</b>                  | > \$3.0 T                                          | Infrastructure privatization; locked-in enterprise/state infrastructure. | Target for structural anti-tech sabotage and tracking backlash. |
| <b>Over 170 Sovereign Nations</b> | < \$1.0 T (Individual GDP)                         | Dependent on imported Western/Chinese models; high fiscal fragility.     | Colonial infrastructure concession arrangements.                |

Table 7

This concentration of power is also, historically speaking, a point of structural vulnerability.

Every period of extreme elite wealth concentration in modern history has either produced reform — through political mobilization that forced redistribution and regulation — or deterioration through social conflict and, in some cases, elite-driven conflict intended to externalize political pressure. The Gilded Age of the 1880s and 1890s in the United States produced, eventually, the Progressive Era reforms of the 1900s and 1910s, themselves accelerated by the political pressure of organized labour and the electoral success of reform movements. The extreme inequality of interwar Europe produced fascism and the Second World War before producing the postwar welfare state. The pattern is not automatic, and the outcomes range from genuine improvement to catastrophic violence.

The techno-oligarchs of the mid-2020s are aware of this pattern, at least implicitly. It is one of the reasons they are buying islands and building bunkers. It is one of the reasons several of them have publicly, if vaguely, engaged with concepts like UBI and "stakeholder capitalism" — gestures toward the recognition that the system producing their wealth is generating political pressure that requires management.

But the security challenge they face is qualitatively different from the security challenges faced by wealthy elites in previous eras, for two reasons.

First, the infrastructure they depend on is vastly more vulnerable to targeted disruption than the infrastructure of previous elite classes. A medieval lord's castle was difficult to take. A Roman senator's villa could be defended. But the server farms, Fiber networks, satellite infrastructure, and supply chains that underpin the wealth and operations of modern technology firms are geographically distributed, dependent on interconnected systems, and vulnerable to cyberattacks, physical sabotage, regulatory intervention, and supply chain disruption in ways that no private security force can fully defend against.

Second, the surveillance and analytical capabilities that give modern technology firms their power are available, in degraded but meaningful form, to their opponents. Encrypted communications enable organizing that was impossible for previous social movements. The same AI tools being deployed for corporate productivity are being used for political mobilization like in Bangladesh, Nepal etc, tactical coordination, and the identification of infrastructure vulnerabilities by Iran and Ukraine war. This does not make resistance movements omnipotent. It does mean the asymmetry of capability between organized power and organized resistance is less extreme than in previous historical periods.

| Dimension         | Corporate / Elite Private Security                                     | Public Law Enforcement Systems                               |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Primary Mandate   | Protection of proprietary assets and elite personnel                   | Broad public safety and municipal code execution             |
| Capabilities      | Route obfuscation, predictive threat intelligence, tactical extraction | Reactive patrol, standard investigation, local crowd control |
| Accountability    | Non-disclosed private corporate contract                               | Public judicial oversight and municipal boards               |
| Operational Scope | Transnational, jurisdictionally flexible                               | Regionally bound by strict administrative legal borders      |

Table 8

The security apparatus around major technology executives has already expanded dramatically. Private security details, travel route obfuscation, residential security

infrastructure, and — in some documented cases — former intelligence community professionals serving as personal security advisors are increasingly standard features of billionaire life. By 2036, if the political pressure intensifies as projected, this apparatus will be considerably more elaborate. The private security industry — already growing faster than the public sector — will have evolved into something resembling private intelligence services, with capabilities that overlap significantly with state functions.

This creates its own political problem. When private entities deploy intelligence capabilities — surveillance, threat assessment, counterintelligence — previously reserved for nation-states, the distinction between public and private power becomes practically meaningless. The wealthy individual who can surveil political opponents, purchase favourable legislation, secure private military protection, and operate from a jurisdiction of his choosing is not, in any functionally meaningful sense, a private citizen. He is a political actor without political accountability, which is a description of a feudal lord as much as it is of a modern billionaire. There are many examples of these already available today and are well known in communities but out of bounds for law enforcement due to their connection and influence to political power. Their donations to political parties shape the policies, the lobbying culture is nothing more than a legalized corruption systems available for highest bidders.

## 12. The Nexus — How Power Networks Will Entrench

The political economy of the next decade will be shaped by the consolidation of what might be called the institutional nexus: the interlocking relationships between major technology companies, the governments that have become dependent on their infrastructure and tax revenue, the financial institutions whose portfolios are concentrated in technology assets, the media ecosystems that operate on technology platforms, and the political class whose campaign finance, information access, and regulatory capacity are all mediated through technology industry relationships.

This nexus is not a conspiracy and can be observed easily. It does not require coordination or agreement to function, and the term itself is used here in the precise sociological sense — a network of structural dependencies producing aligned outcomes without requiring shared intent. It is an emergent property of incentive alignment: each actor in the system has independent reasons to maintain the relationships that sustain it, and those relationships collectively produce policy outcomes that protect the system regardless of any individual actor's explicit intent. The phenomenon is well-documented in the academic literature on regulatory capture, institutional capture, and elite network theory, and it does not require imputing bad faith to any particular individual.

Regulatory capture in technology markets is already well-documented. The revolving door between major technology firms and the regulatory agencies responsible for overseeing them — FTC, FCC, NLRB, SEC, and their counterparts in Europe and Asia — is not a recent phenomenon, but it has intensified as the complexity of the regulatory domain has increased. The expertise required to regulate advanced AI systems, semiconductor supply chains, and digital financial infrastructure is predominantly held by people who developed that expertise in the private sector and who have reasonable expectations of returning to it.

Campaign finance flows make the structure explicit in financial terms. Technology industry political giving has expanded significantly over the past decade, and the alignment between major donors' policy preferences and the policy positions of both major American parties on issues like antitrust, labour regulation, and AI governance is not coincidental. Similar patterns are visible in Europe, Japan, South Korea, and India.

By 2036, on current trajectories and absent deliberate antitrust or governance intervention, the institutional nexus will in all likelihood have deepened and become structurally more difficult to challenge. AI systems will progressively be embedded in government operations — tax administration, benefits determination, border control, defence procurement, judicial support — in ways that create functional dependencies on specific technology vendors. Governments that outsource critical infrastructure to private technology firms have consistently found that subsequent regulatory pressure against those firms creates operational risk that constrains their



practical independence. This is not speculation about novel dynamics. It is the documented pattern of every previous major government technology dependency, from IT companies' relationship with the federal government since 1960s to current relationships with defence and intelligence agencies. The pattern could be interrupted by deliberate procurement diversification, open-source government infrastructure mandates, or antitrust action — none of which is currently on a policy trajectory sufficient to offset it.

The popular perception of this nexus — which will be more vivid by 2036, when its consequences are more materially felt — will be a significant driver of political instability. Trust in institutions is already at historic lows across most major democracies, per the Edelman Trust Barometer's 2024 findings. The specific perception that government and corporate power have merged to serve concentrated private interests at the expense of public welfare is already a major driver of political radicalization across the ideological spectrum. By 2036, that perception will have accumulated a decade of additional evidence.

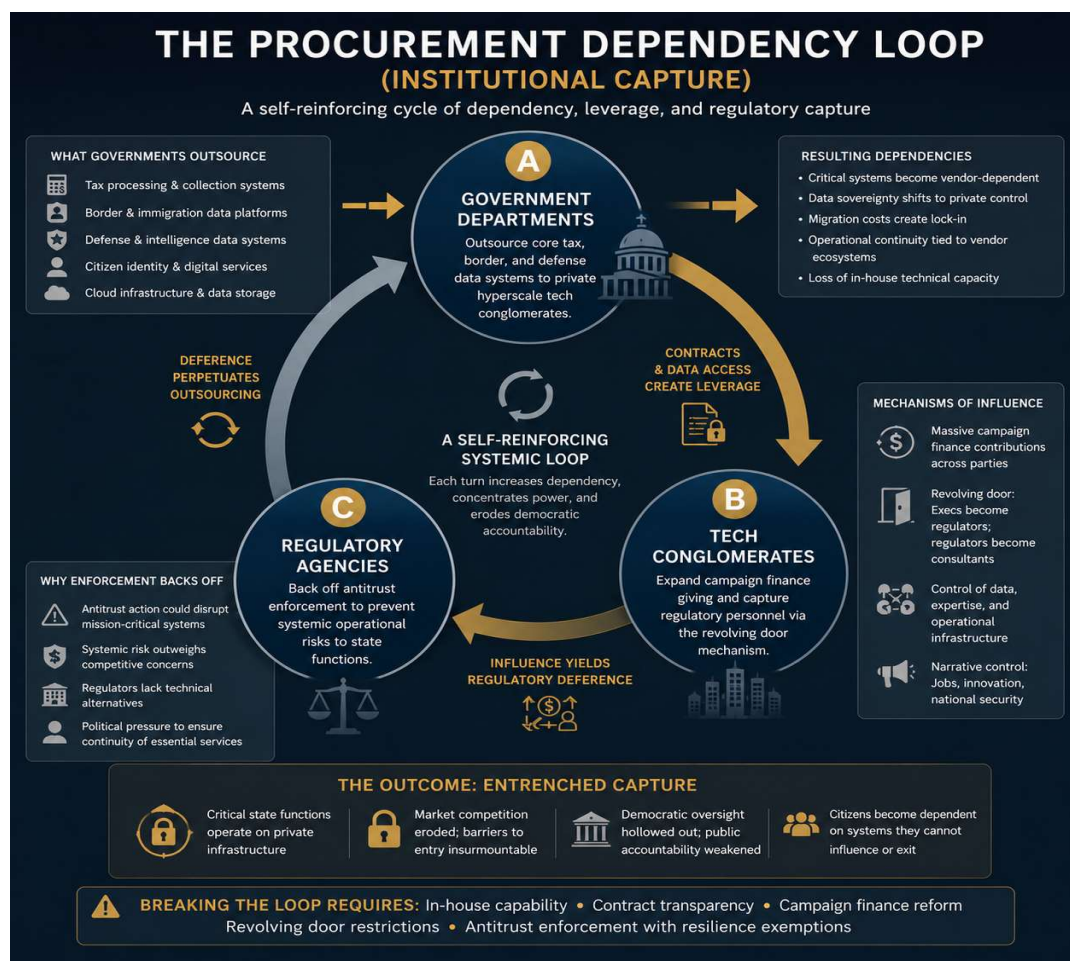


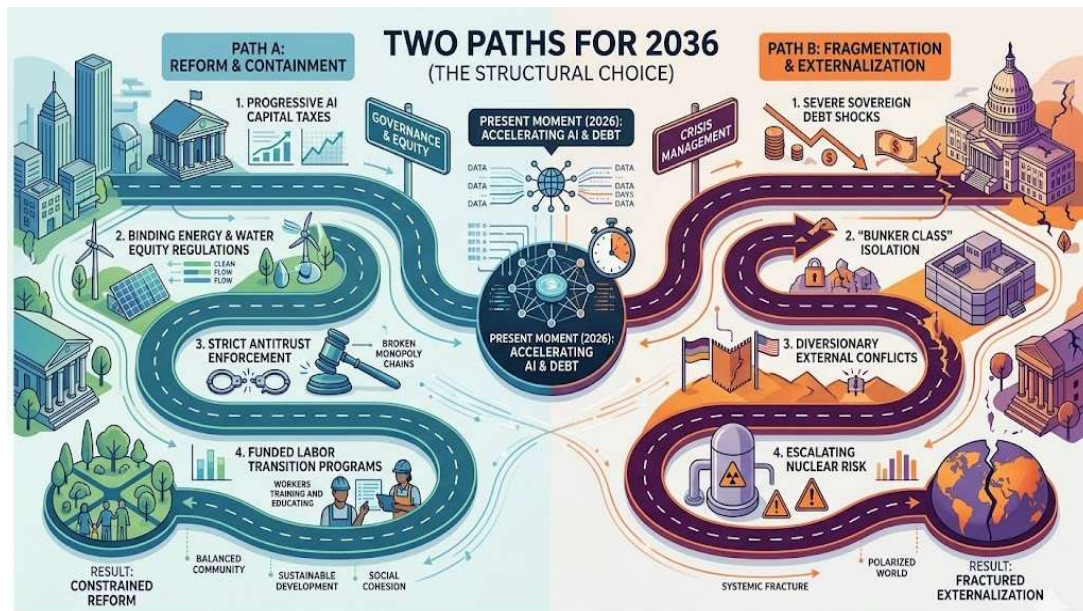
Figure 12

The movements that organize against the nexus will be heterogeneous and sometimes ideologically incoherent — comprising libertarian anti-government sentiment, left-wing anti-corporate politics, nationalist anti-globalization movements, and various forms of communitarian resistance to technological disruption. Their internal contradictions will limit their capacity for sustained collective action. But their shared emotional reality — the sense that the system is rigged, that the rules have been rewritten by and for a small class of powerful actors — will provide sufficient common ground for periodic coalitions that can produce real political pressure.

History offers examples of these cross-ideological coalitions: the Progressive Era alliance of rural populists and urban reformers, the postwar Keynesian consensus that united labour and capital around managed growth, and the anti-globalization movement that brought together environmentalists, labour unions, and nationalist politicians in the 1990s and 2000s. Each was unstable and temporary. Each produced real policy change before fracturing.

### 13. Two Futures — Reform or Catastrophe

The central uncertainty of the next decade is not technological. It is political. The question is whether the accumulating pressure of popular resistance will be channelled into systemic reform — producing a new social contract adequate to the realities of AI-driven economic transformation — or whether it will be managed, deflected, and ultimately externalized in ways that produce conflict rather than resolution.



A conceptual roadmap of the structural choices facing governing coalitions between system reform and crisis externalization.

**Figure 13**

There is a genuine reform path, and it is worth describing concretely before discussing why it may not be taken.

A reformed political economy for the AI era would include: progressive taxation of AI-driven capital gains and corporate profits sufficient to fund meaningful public investment; binding regulations on AI energy and water consumption with equity provisions protecting residential and public institution access; serious antitrust enforcement that prevents further monopolization of critical digital infrastructure; labour transition programs with realistic funding and timelines; and international agreements on AI governance that include developing world interests rather than simply encoding the preferences of wealthy technology-exporting nations.

None of these policies is technically novel. The analytic frameworks exist. The historical precedents exist — the New Deal, the postwar welfare state, the European social market economy. The post-World War II Bretton Woods system demonstrated that international economic coordination producing broadly shared benefits is

achievable, at least under conditions of sufficient political will and institutional capacity.

| <b>Policy Objective</b>             | <b>Technical Implementation Mechanism</b>               | <b>Primary Political Obstructor</b>   | <b>Target Revenue / Impact</b>                         |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Progressive Capital Taxation</b> | Automated AI-driven capital gains levy                  | Tech Lobby / Venture Portfolios       | Funding for labor transitional safety nets.            |
| <b>Binding Energy Equity</b>        | Mandated baseload priority floors for public usage      | Hyperscale Operators / Grid Utilities | Protection of public hospitals/schools from rationing. |
| <b>Antitrust De-monopolization</b>  | Strict infrastructure unbundling and compute separation | Institutional Nexus / Tech Oligarchs  | Open market access to open-source foundation models.   |

*Table 9*

The obstacle is political, not analytical. Each of these reforms directly threatens the financial interests of actors with extraordinary resources to resist them. The priority contracting model, AI tax arrangements, antitrust constraints, labour protections like one recent judgement in China where court ordered the employees cannot be fired just because technological advancements were achieved, and energy equity regulations are collectively worth, to the firms that benefit from their absence, hundreds of billions of dollars annually. Those firms have demonstrated willingness and capacity to spend exceptionally large amounts of money defending those interests — in lobbying, campaign finance, institutional relationships, media influence, and legal strategy.

The reform path requires a political coalition strong enough and durable enough to overcome that resistance. The historical precedents for such coalitions forming are real, but they typically required either a shock severe enough to delegitimize the existing arrangements — a depression, a war, a clearly visible catastrophe — or a long organizational process that built sufficient institutional power to prevail despite elite opposition.

The alternative — the externalization path — has its own historical precedents, and they are darker.



## 14. When Governments Manufacture Enemies — The Externalization of Crisis

There is a pattern in the political history of societies under severe internal stress: when domestic contradictions become too acute to resolve through normal political processes, governing coalitions find it useful to focus attention on external threats, real or exaggerated. The mechanism is well-documented in the academic literature on diversionary war theory and in the historical record of the late Roman Republic, the interwar European powers, and numerous post-colonial states.

This is not a cynical conspiracy theory. It is a structural observation: governments facing severe internal legitimacy crises have consistently found that external conflict — or the credible threat of external conflict — produces several politically useful effects. It generates national unity across class and economic lines, at least temporarily. It justifies emergency powers that allow executive action without normal democratic constraints. It provides an explanation for economic hardship — sanctions, defense spending, wartime sacrifice — that deflects blame from domestic policy choices. And it activates patriotic and nationalist sentiment that is more politically manageable than class-based economic anger.

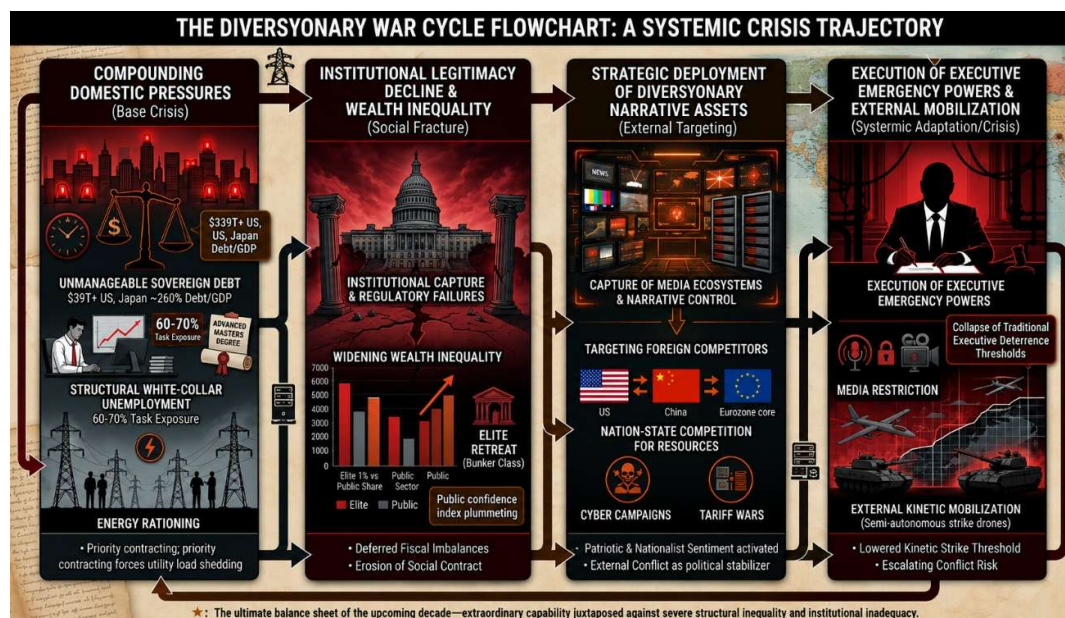


Figure 14

By 2036, multiple major powers will be operating under conditions of significant internal political stress: severe sovereign debt, labour market disruption, energy constraint, institutional legitimacy crises, and mounting popular anger at elite enrichment. The geopolitical environment will simultaneously offer genuine external tensions — Taiwan, the South China Sea, the Arctic, resource competition in Africa, Middle East instability — that can be amplified or deliberately escalated.

The risk, which serious analysts at institutions including RAND, the Carnegie Endowment, and the International Crisis Group have been modelling for several years, is that domestic political pressure in one or more major powers produces a deliberate escalation of external conflict designed to serve internal political purposes. This is the externalization scenario. It is not inevitable. It is not even necessarily the most likely outcome. But it is a plausible consequence of the political dynamics being set in motion right now, and its potential severity makes it the most important risk to analyse seriously.

The interwar analogy is instructive but requires care. The political economy of the 1920s and 1930s featured sovereign debt crises, technological displacement (mechanized agriculture producing rural unemployment), extreme wealth concentration, institutional failures, and rising nationalist political movements — several structural similarities to the current period. The outcome was not inevitable. Multiple decision points existed at which different choices could have produced different outcomes. What made the catastrophic outcome more likely was the combination of weak democratic institutions, inadequate social safety nets, a world monetary system under severe strain, and governing elites who chose to ride nationalist sentiment rather than address the underlying economic grievances.

The critical differences from the current period include the existence of nuclear weapons, which fundamentally change the calculus of major power conflict in ways that were not present in 1939, and the existence of international institutions — however weakened — that provide at least some framework for managing tensions short of armed conflict.



## 15. The Nuclear Shadow — The Scenario Nobody Wants to Name

The most extreme risk in this analysis is also the one most consistently avoided in mainstream political and economic discussion: the possibility that the combination of internal civil and political crisis, external geopolitical competition, and the availability of nuclear arsenals produce a nuclear exchange.

Let it be stated clearly: this is not the most probable outcome. The deterrence framework has held for eighty years through crises that seemed, in retrospect, extremely dangerous. The rationality of mutual assured destruction theory has consequences, and has been so far, constrained decision-makers even under severe pressure.

But the components of that deterrence framework — particularly the assumption that decision-makers are rational actors with complete information operating without domestic political constraints — are being tested in ways that deserve serious examination rather than polite avoidance.

First, the domestic political pressures driving externalization create incentives for nuclear states to take risks they would not otherwise take. A government facing severe internal legitimacy collapse has different risk tolerance than a government operating in conditions of political stability. The leader whose domestic political survival depends on projecting strength and national purpose has different calculations than the leader whose position is secure. This is the risk that political scientists call "gambling for resurrection" — the tendency of politically desperate actors to accept gambles they know are dangerous because the alternative — doing nothing — feels equally fatal to their political position.

Second, the proliferation of nuclear capabilities and the degradation of arms control architecture have expanded the set of actors who could initiate nuclear use. The nuclear arsenals of Russia, China, the United States, France, the United Kingdom, Pakistan, India, Israel, and North Korea represent a complex web of deterrence relationships, none of which is as stable or as well-modelled as the bilateral U.S.-Soviet relationship that dominated Cold War strategic thinking. The collapse of the INF Treaty, the uncertain future of New START, and the failure to develop meaningful arms control frameworks covering Chinese capabilities represent real deteriorations in the institutional management of nuclear risk.

Third — and here is the element that connects most directly to the economic and political dynamics of this analysis — there is a documented strand of thinking in academic strategic literature and among some analysts who take civilizational risk seriously that distinguishes between a "controlled" nuclear exchange and civilization-ending nuclear war. The logic, which appears in published arms control scholarship and scenario planning, is deeply uncomfortable but not difficult to follow: if a nuclear exchange could be limited to specific targets, kept below certain yield like a tactical nuclear weapon and geographic thresholds, and managed by parties with sufficient advance preparation — bunkers, hardened communication

infrastructure, supply reserves — then its strategic parameters might be calculable in ways that would be irrational to contemplate in the context of full-scale nuclear war. It bears emphasis that no nuclear state's official doctrine endorses this framing, and the overwhelming weight of strategic analysis treats limited nuclear war as a dangerous illusion given escalation dynamics.

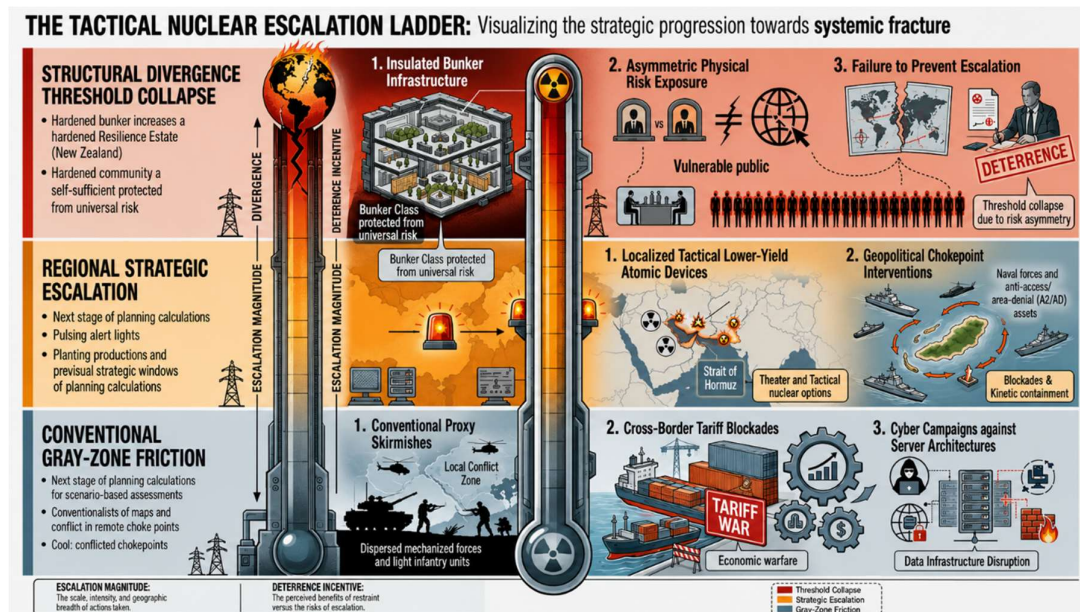


Figure 15

This thinking is not mainstream. It is not the official doctrine of any nuclear state. But it is present — in academic strategic literature, in the conversations of people who take civilizational risk seriously enough to have built hardened residential facilities, and in the implicit logic of the investments being made by the class of people who believe they could survive scenarios that would kill everyone else.

The moral obscenity of this logic does not diminish its analytical relevance. The people building bunkers and acquiring remote island properties are, implicitly, pricing in a scenario in which a catastrophic geopolitical event occurs and a small number of prepared individuals survive to rebuild or to maintain their position in whatever political order emerges. This is not paranoid fantasy — it is the explicit premise of the survivalist investment thesis, stated openly in real estate marketing materials and, less explicitly, in the risk assessments of the people making these purchases.

What this means for the political dynamics of the 2030s is that the externalization of crisis through conflict is not, from the perspective of the people with the most resources and the most hardened infrastructure, an unambiguous catastrophe. For a small class of actors, a controlled conflict that eliminates political pressure from economically displaced populations, resets the global political order, and leaves

their own infrastructure and assets intact could be — in the coldest possible analytical terms — an outcome they are prepared for and, therefore, one they may be less motivated to prevent than the general population would wish.

This is not an accusation. It is a structural observation about the divergence of risk exposure that extreme wealth concentration and survivalist investment produces. When the people making major decisions have materially different exposure to the consequences of those decisions than the people affected by them, the incentive structures that normally constrain dangerous choices are weakened.

## 16. What People Will Actually Do — The Realistic Range of Resistance

Against this backdrop, what will popular resistance to the AI-driven political economy actually look like?

The most likely trajectory combines several layers of action developing in parallel and occasionally reinforcing each other.

The electoral layer will produce continued political volatility — the rise and fall of movements and parties articulating economic grievances in the language of anti-elite populism, across ideological spectrums, in multiple countries simultaneously. Some of these will produce genuine policy change. Some will be captured by the nexus they nominally oppose, channelling popular anger toward cultural targets rather than structural ones. Some will produce governing coalitions that implement nationalist-protectionist policies — trade barriers, immigration restriction, industrial policy — that address some symptoms of the underlying problem without resolving the core distributional crisis.

The direct-action layer will produce periodic disruptions of AI infrastructure — cyberattacks, physical interference with data centres and energy facilities, and targeted actions against the properties and operations of technology executives. These will generally be characterized by governments as criminal or extremist, regardless of their political character, because the infrastructure being targeted is strategically important and the interests defending it are politically powerful. The domestic security apparatus in most countries will expand its monitoring and disruption capabilities focused on anti-AI and anti-tech-oligarchy organizing. This expansion will itself become a political grievance, driving further radicalization in a feedback loop that historical precedents suggest is difficult to interrupt.

The international layer will produce coalitions of developing world governments — in forums including the G7, the African Union, and various regional bodies — pressing for redistribution of AI economic gains, technology transfer requirements, and constraints on data extraction. These pressures will produce some policy responses at the margin but will face the same structural obstacles as similar coalitions have faced in previous decades: the concentration of institutional power in wealthy technology-exporting nations, the vulnerability of developing world economies to financial pressure from institutions those nations control, and the fragmentation of interests within the Global South itself.

The possibility of genuine cross-class, cross-ideological coalitions — moments when the shared experience of economic precarity, surveillance, and institutional failure produces temporary unity among groups that are otherwise divided — is real. These have occurred historically: the strikes and political movements of the early twentieth century brought together groups with deeply divergent interests around shared economic grievances. The anti-apartheid movement created international coalitions across ideological divides. The global financial crisis of 2008 briefly produced cross-ideological critique of financial system failures.



Figure 16

By the early 2030s, several conditions for such coalitions will be present: a shared grievance visible across class lines in the form of energy rationing and service deterioration, the material reality of AI job displacement affecting enough people to constitute a political majority in several countries, and — critically — the visibility of elite withdrawal into private resilience infrastructure, which has historically been a powerful political trigger. The Roman mob did not storm the Praetorian palace because of abstract principle. They did it when bread was expensive and senators were eating well. The specific modern equivalent — energy rationed for public hospitals while data centre campuses are on protected supply — is precisely the kind of visible, symbolically legible injustice that historically catalyses political mobilization.



## 17. The Two Possible Endings to This Decade

The decade between 2026 and 2036 will likely end in one of two broad configurations, with many variations within each.

In the first configuration — call it the Constrained Reform scenario — the accumulating political pressure of popular resistance, combined with the genuine fiscal and governance crises that current trajectories are producing, creates sufficient political will to implement meaningful reform. Tax regimes capture more of the AI productivity gains and redirect them toward public systems. Energy allocation regulations establish meaningful floors for residential and public institution access. Antitrust action breaks up some of the most extreme infrastructure monopolies. Labor transition programs provide realistic support for displaced workers. International AI governance frameworks — imperfect and incomplete — establish some constraints on the most destabilizing deployment patterns.

This outcome does not require optimism about human nature. It mainly requires that the political cost of inaction — in the form of continued electoral volatility, infrastructure disruption, governance crisis, and the genuine fiscal deterioration of maintaining a system that cannot sustain itself — eventually exceeds the political cost of reform. Historical precedents suggest this threshold can be reached. The New Deal, the postwar welfare state, and the managed transition from colonial empire to post-colonial development assistance were all responses to systems that had become politically unsustainable. They were imperfect, contested, and partial. They were better than the alternative.

In the second configuration — call it the Fractured Externalization scenario — the reform path is blocked by the combination of institutional capture, elite resistance, and ideological fragmentation long enough that the structural contradictions produce unmanageable crises. Financial system stress in multiple sovereigns simultaneously produces a contraction that overwhelms existing institutional mechanisms. Geopolitical competition over semiconductor supply chains, energy resources, and regional sphere-of-influence claims produces escalating conflicts, with one or more becoming serious armed confrontations. Domestic political instability in major powers — amplified by the AI-driven information environment that has made propaganda more sophisticated and consensus more fragile — produces governing coalitions that choose external conflict as a pressure-release mechanism.

In this configuration, the nuclear risk of becoming material is extremely high rather than theoretical. Not a planned, "controlled" nuclear exchange — the impossibility of controlling nuclear escalation once initiated has been demonstrated in war games and academic modelling repeatedly. But a crisis escalation driven by the combination of domestic political desperation, miscalculation, and the reduced deterrence credibility that comes from leaders whose domestic political survival depends on projecting strength. The people in the bunkers, if this scenario unfolds, will have been rational actors and Majority unprotected will pay the price

## 18. What Artificial Intelligence Will Have Actually Solved

Before the conclusion, it is essential to inventory what will genuinely be accomplished — because the genuine accomplishments are real and significant, and their existence is not incompatible with the structural risks this report describes.

AI-assisted drug discovery is already demonstrably accelerating pharmaceutical research timelines. AlphaFold's protein structure prediction breakthrough has been described by structural biologists as one of the most significant advances in the field's history. Early-stage cancer detection through AI imaging analysis is already showing improved accuracy in clinical deployments. Agricultural AI is contributing to food security in regions where it has been deployed. Climate modelling has been enhanced by AI analytical capacity in ways that have materially improved the precision of policy-relevant projections.

Scientific research in physics, chemistry, materials science, and mathematics has been transformed in ways researchers describe as qualitatively different from previous computational tools. Problems that would have taken doctoral students' years to explore can now be computationally investigated in days. The funnel of promising research directions has widened substantially. What this report has given less attention to — and analytical honesty requires acknowledging it — is AI's potential as a governance and institutional tool, not merely a destabilising economic force. AI-assisted regulatory analysis can, in principle, improve the quality of policy decisions by processing more evidence faster and flagging unintended consequences that human analysts miss. Energy grid optimisation using AI is already reducing waste in several national electricity systems and could, if deployed at scale, materially reduce the demand pressures described in earlier sections. Anti-corruption applications — pattern detection in public procurement, financial flows, and regulatory filings — represent a genuine counterforce to the institutional capture dynamics this report describes. Administrative efficiency gains in public services could, in theory, partially offset the fiscal pressures driving service deterioration. These are not rhetorical gestures toward balance. They are real capabilities that exist and are being deployed in some contexts. The critical uncertainty is whether they will be deployed at scale, with genuine access, within the public and democratic institutions that most need them — or whether, as with so many previous productivity-enhancing technologies their most powerful applications accrue to well-resourced private actors first, deepening structural asymmetries rather than correcting them. Historical precedents in the pharmaceutical sector illustrate this exact hazard. For decades, major corporate actors have leveraged aggressive patent protections to maintain high price thresholds on life-saving therapeutics, effectively blocking the synthesis of low-cost generics to protect profit margins. If advanced AI capabilities are governed under similar proprietary monopolies, the technology will function as an instrument of economic extraction rather than a public good.

| Technical Innovation                 | Public Good Deployment Framework                   | Current Proprietary Monopoly Realities                              |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Protein Structure Prediction         | Open-source academic drug synthesis labs           | Locked down by pharmaceutical patent walls.                         |
| Climate Modeling / Grid Optimization | Dynamic municipal energy distribution allocation   | Proprietary optimization maximizing private data center efficiency. |
| Anti-Corruption Tracking             | Automated auditing of public procurement contracts | Hidden behind corporate confidentiality and trade secrets.          |

Table 10

These achievements will continue and deepen over the next decade. They will produce real improvements in human welfare for those who have access to them. The prediction of this report is not that artificial intelligence will succeed or fail. It is that artificial intelligence will succeed within a system that is failing—and that success within a failing system can make the failure harder to see and harder to interrupt.

The diagnostic machine works brilliantly. The elevator does not. The power goes out. And somewhere, three kilometres away, a small crowd of people who used to have jobs — and still have enough political energy to stand outside a building holding signs — are waiting for someone with power to notice that the system is not working for them.

Whether anyone with power notices, and whether that noticing produces action, is the central question of the next ten years.

## 19. The Breaking Point — What History Tells Us to Expect

The historical weight of the present moment cannot be overstated, even though the instinct of people living through structural crises is typically to treat current arrangements as more durable than they are.

Edward Gibbon's analysis of Rome's decline attributed it to military overextension, fiscal deterioration, institutional corruption, and a gradual erosion of civic investment — a multi-causal analysis that modern historians have refined but not fundamentally overturned and seems similar to USA with more than 800 bases across the world and regular necessity of wars to run military industrial complex. Joseph Tainter's systematic work emphasizes diminishing returns to social complexity: as societies invest more in administrative and institutional structures to solve their problems, the marginal benefit of additional complexity eventually turns negative. Collapse — simplification — becomes a functional adaptation rather than merely a catastrophe.

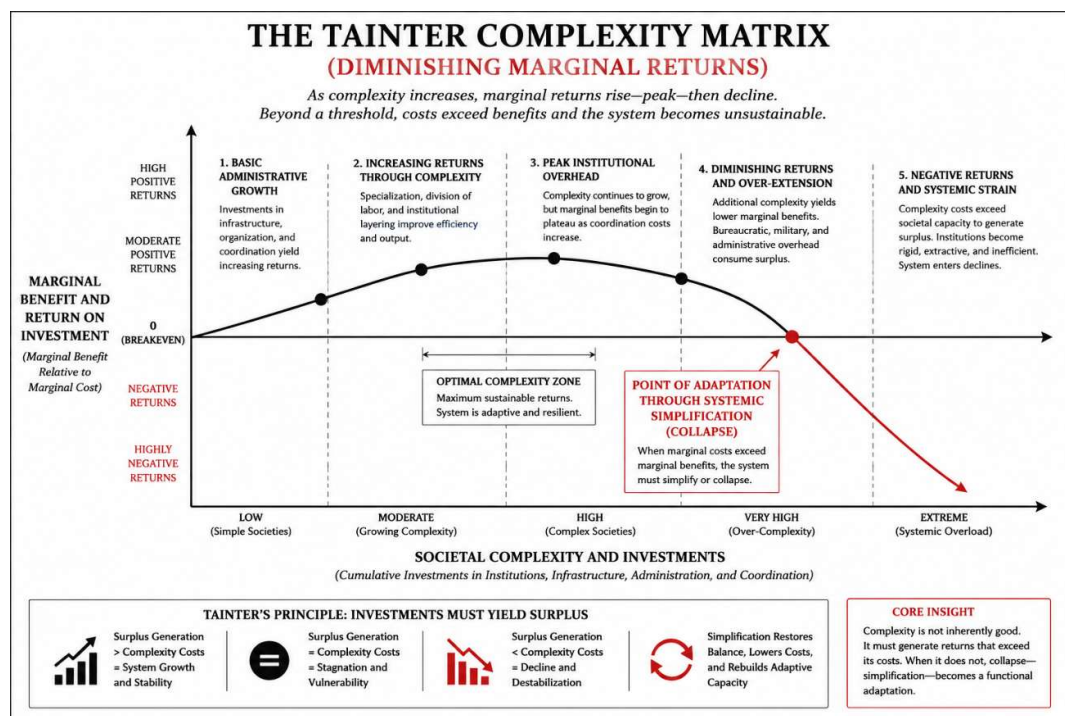


Figure 17

Barbara Tuchman's "The March of Folly" documented, across multiple historical civilizations, the capacity of governing elites to persist in policies demonstrably contrary to their own stated interests and their populations' welfare — not because they were stupid, but because the institutional and personal incentives that sustained those policies were stronger than the evidence that they were failing. The Trojan leaders who rejected offers to return Helen and end the war, the British who held India past the point of sustainability, the American strategists who continued

Vietnam — in each case, intelligent people in possession of accurate information chose institutional continuity over structural adaptation.

The current moment has the structural characteristics that historical analysis suggests produce either reform or catastrophic rupture. The speed of the technological transformation is faster than any previous analog. The scale of capital concentration is greater where 40% of the S&P 500 is just made by these tech AI companies. The institutional frameworks are more eroded at the starting point. The geopolitical competition is more complex with current situation of dealing with ruptured supply chain, resource crunch, tariff war, destruction of energy infrastructure and fight for global influence and positioning as global power that involves more nuclear actors than at most previous inflection points in modern history.

The reform path is available. Its technical requirements are clear. Its political requirements are severe. The externalization path is also available. Its technical requirements are the same political and military machinery that has always been available to governing elites under pressure. Its consequences, in a nuclear-armed multipolar world, would be categorically worse than anything produced by previous episodes of externalization.

The choice between them is, in a democratic society, ultimately a political one. It will be shaped by whether the people experiencing the costs of the current trajectory — the woman in the hospital stairwell, the analyst in Bogotá whose credentials bought nothing, the teacher explaining "resilience education" to children in coats — can organize sufficient political pressure to make reform more politically attractive to governing coalitions than the alternatives.

That is not guaranteed. But it is possible. And the window in which it is possible is narrower than most people are currently acknowledging.



## 20. Conclusion — Intelligence Without Wisdom Is a Very Expensive Problem

When the history of this period is written — whether by people living in a society that navigated the transition toward something equitable and stable, or by people living in the aftermath of a society that did not — the central question will not be whether the technology worked. It did. It will. The question will be whether the political and institutional systems in which it was embedded were capable of governing it in the common interest.

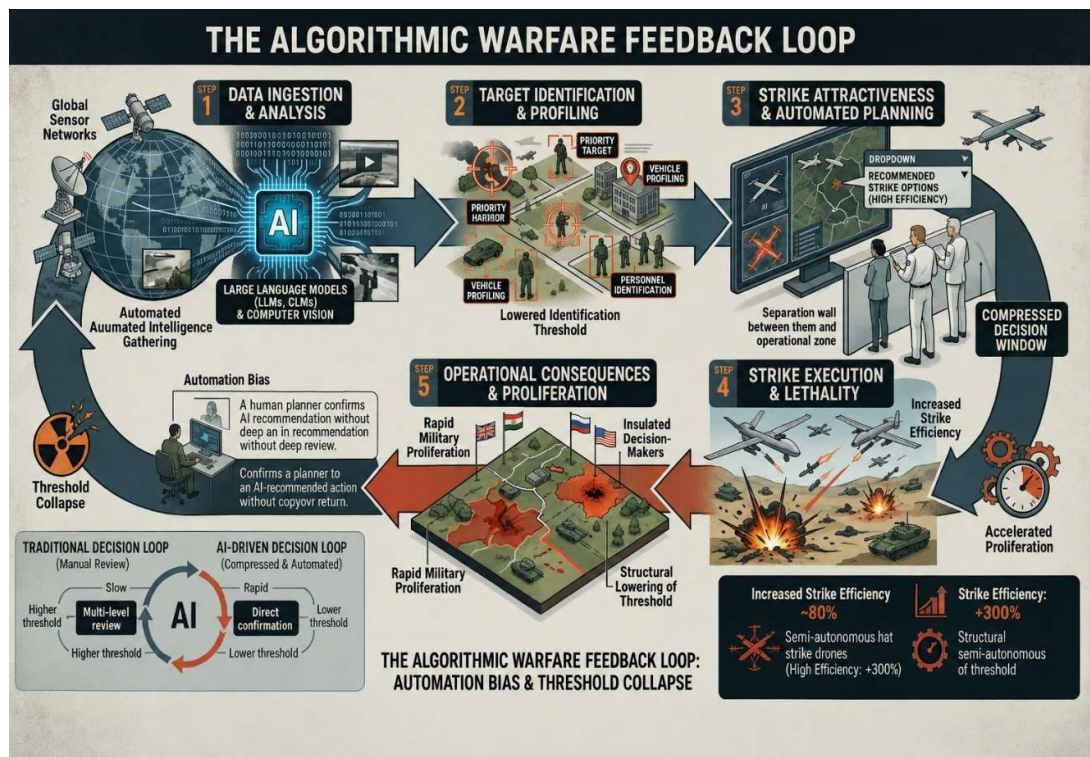


Figure 18

The answer to that question is being written right now, in the priority contracts being signed between technology companies and energy utilities, in the tax arrangements being negotiated between AI firms and governments, in the regulatory decisions being made about market concentration and labour standards, in the military doctrine being updated for autonomous systems, in the surveillance infrastructure being normalized through private platforms, and in the bunkers being built and islands being acquired by people who have modelled the risks and decided that individual preparation is a better investment than collective reform.

History does not deal in certainties. Every structural crisis that produced catastrophe had, in retrospect, multiple decision points at which a different choice could have produced a different outcome. Every structural crisis that produced reform required

people who were willing to bear the political cost of challenging entrenched interests and the analytical cost of articulating an alternative clearly enough to build a coalition around it.

The artificial intelligence being built right now is the most powerful tool humanity has ever created. It is already solving problems that resisted solution for generations. By 2036, it will have solved more. The tragedy — if tragedy is what unfolds — will not be that the tool failed. It will be that the tool was brilliant and the society wielding it was not wise enough, or just enough, or institutionally robust enough, to direct it toward the common good.

That is the intelligence dividend: extraordinary technical capability, distributed with extraordinary inequality, governed with extraordinary inadequacy, in a world that desperately needed all three to be otherwise.

The woman in the stairwell is still waiting. The crowd outside the electricity board is still holding their signs. The bunkers are being stocked. The contracts are being signed. The models are being trained.

The next ten years will determine which of these images defines the decade.

We are, at this moment, still in a position to influence the answer.

That window will not remain open indefinitely.

*This investigation draws on publicly available economic data, published research, documented geopolitical developments, and historical analysis current as of May 2026. All projections regarding 2036 are explicitly forward-looking estimates, not established facts. They are extrapolations from documented trends and should be understood as scenarios — plausible consequences of current trajectories, subject to change through political, technological, or institutional developments not yet in evidence. The entire effort of this report is to invoke the thought process of policy makers that which path they want for their countries and societies as at the end of the countries or nation states are nothing more than the people who represent them, without people or with fractured intention of nationhood will also lead to fracture of the state itself.*

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